

INBRIEF



Tejashwi writes to Bihar CM over issues of PDS vendors

The Leader of the Opposition in Bihar Assembly, Tejashwi Yadav, on Wednesday wrote to Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary over the demands and issues of Public Distribution System (PDS) vendors of the State. In his letter Mr. Yadav said that PDS vendors are facing severe financial crisis due to record-breaking inflation, mounting administrative hurdles, delays in commission payments, and technical issues. He demanded that PDS vendors should be provided a fixed monthly honorarium of at least ₹30,000, following the model adopted by the Gujarat government.

Fire erupts in Surat textile market; many shops damaged

A massive fire erupted at a multi-storey textile market in Gujarat's Surat city, damaging more than a dozen shops and leaving a firefighter injured, police said on Wednesday. The fire broke out around midnight in the Shyam Sangini textile market and affected shops located on its sixth floor, they said. As many as 25 firefighting vehicles, turntable ladders, hydraulic platforms and nearly 150 fire personnel and officers were deployed to control the blaze, Chief Fire Officer Basant Pareek said. The blaze was brought under control in around eight hours, he said. Local traders said the fire destroyed synthetic goods kept outside the shops on the sixth floor. PTI

Clashes mar first phase of Rajasthan urban polls

Press Trust of India
JAIPUR

A tentative 72.09% voter turnout was recorded in the first phase of Rajasthan's urban local body elections on Wednesday, with incidents of clashes, alleged bogus voting and EVM-related disruptions reported from some places.

In Fatehpur of Sikar district, stone-pelting took place between supporters of a Congress candidate and an independent candidate, in which two people were injured.

In the Jhunjhunu Municipal Council's Ward 35, CPI(M) candidate Mahipal Poonia alleged bogus voting and claimed that police personnel were supporting those casting fraudulent votes. Earlier in the day, EVM-related disruptions were also reported at several places.

1,169 candidates set to win unopposed in Tripura village polls

Syed Sajjad Ali
AGARTALA

A record number of candidates contesting the upcoming village committee elections under the Tripura Tribal Areas Autonomous District Council are set to win unopposed owing to the lack of rival nominations.

The State Election Commission (SEC) said on Wednesday that polling will not be held in 1,169 seats, accounting for one-third of the 4,597 seats across 587 village committees, because only solitary nominations have been received. The SEC said scrutiny of all the 10,958 nominations filed was conducted during the day.

Most of the candidates set to win unopposed belong to the Tipra Motha. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), the Tipra Motha, and

the Indigenous People's Front of Tripura had earlier announced that they would jointly contest the elections. However, the three parties have failed to arrive at a seat-sharing formula so far. A senior Minister said the alliance is nothing but an arrangement to keep the CPI(M) and the Congress at bay.

Contesting same seats
The Tipra Motha and the BJP have even fielded candidates for the same seats in several village committees. September 10 is the last date for withdrawal of nominations.

The SEC assured that the elections would be held in a peaceful manner on September 28. It added that the Ministry of Home Affairs has sanctioned 24 companies of Central forces to be deployed in sensitive areas in the State.

Revanth orders probe into remarks against Speaker, 'purification' controversy

BRS cadre had reportedly sprinkled turmeric water on roads used by Cong. Dalit workers to reach KCR's farmhouse; Assembly terms incident 'attack on self-respect of Dalits and Telangana society'

R. Ravikanth Reddy
P. Laxma Reddy
HYDERABAD

Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy on Wednesday announced an inquiry into the incidents that occurred from Sunday, including the alleged conspiracy behind the alleged abusive remarks made by Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) MLCs against Legislative Assembly Speaker Gad-dam Prasad Kumar.

Hyderabad City Joint Commissioner of Police Vijay Kumar will head the investigation, which would cover the sequence of events leading to the alleged remarks against the Speaker and examine whether there was any larger conspiracy behind the incidents.

The Chief Minister made the announcement in the Assembly during a discussion on the "purification" of roads leading to BRS president and Leader of the Opposition K. Chandrash-ekhar Rao's (KCR) farm-



Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy speaking in the State Assembly on Wednesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

house in Erravelli. BRS workers had sprinkled turmeric water on the roads used by Congress Dalit workers to reach the farmhouse for a protest.

"The government would investigate not only those who allegedly made the offensive remarks but also those who planned and participated in the alleged conspiracy," he said. A comprehensive investigation will be conducted, criminal cases will be registered and those responsible will be punished, he added.

The House condemned

the incident stating that it was a crime and an attack on the self-respect of Dalits and the Telangana society.

The Chief Minister alleged that the BRS had conspired at a farmhouse to provoke its legislators to disrupt the Assembly proceedings as it feared that discussions would expose the corruption, irregularities and debts during the BRS regime.

'Derogatory comments'
"Those who attack Parliam-ent... terrorists responsible for the Pulwama attack and those who insult the

Speaker with casteist mind-set cannot be treated very differently," Mr. Reddy said, in reference to the alleged derogatory comments of BRS MLCs. He alleged that some BRS members not only attacked officials but also insulted the dignity of the Speaker's chair and made remarks against Mr. Prasad.

Tension had prevailed for several hours on Tuesday near the farmhouse of KCR at Erravelli in Siddipet district as Congress workers and Dalit organisations attempted to march towards the premises as part of a 'Chavu Dappu' (funeral drum-beating) protest against alleged derogatory remarks made against Dalits by BRS leaders.

Scuffles broke out between BRS workers and protesters at some checkpoints. The police also stopped hundreds of protesters who later staged a demonstration several hundred metres from the farmhouse, and raising slogans. A few police personnel suffered minor injuries.

Will uproot forces raising 'anti-national' slogans: Bengal CM

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Wednesday renewed his pledge to "uproot" forces raising slogans such as "Kashmir demands freedom" on the Jadavpur University (JU) campus and said he would not tolerate any insult to the saffron colour.

Mr. Adhikari was addressing a gathering outside the campus after leading the 'Gerua Samman Yatra'. The march, from Golpark to Jadavpur, was attended by hundreds of saints and seers dressed in saffron. Thousands of people and several MLAs also took part in the march.

"I have taken a vow that in Jadavpur, those who raise slogans like 'Kashmir mange azaadi' and 'red salute to Kishenji (slain Maoist leader)' and write 'gerua gundami (saffron hooliganism)', I will rip you out from your roots," Mr. Adhikari said.

The Chief Minister had recently called for an inquiry into alleged "anti-national" graffiti and posters that surfaced on the JU campus following alleged clashes between students belonging to the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad and Left-leaning groups



Suwendu Adhikari taking part in the 'Gerua Samman Yatra' in Kolkata on Wednesday. PTI

such as the Students' Federation of India.

Addressing the gathering, he said he would come back to Jadavpur twice – once to teach a lesson to the people who are insulting saffron and the nation, and then to recite the Gita and the Hanuman Chalisa.

Mr. Adhikari warned that people should "think five times" before making or writing offensive remarks about the saffron colour. He said any such insult would not be tolerated by the BJP government.

New appointments
Meanwhile, JU removed Acting Registrar Selim Baksh Mondal and appointed Debjit Dutta as the interim Registrar. Indrajit Bandyopadhyay was appointed as the Acting Finance Officer in place of Shiladitya Chattopadhyay.

Parties express concern over razing of Saharanpur mosque, Moradabad notice

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW



A century-old mosque located inside the Saharanpur Collectorate complex was demolished on September 5. FILE PHOTO

Opposition parties in Uttar Pradesh on Wednesday expressed concern that targeting of mosques and structures linked to the Muslim community will intensify across the State in view of the upcoming Assembly election in a bid to polarise people.

The concern comes against the backdrop of the demolition of a century-old mosque inside the Saharanpur Collectorate complex on September 5 and authorities in Moradabad issuing notice recently to the management of the Mustafa Mosque, describing it as an "unauthorised construction". The Moradabad Development Authority notice dated August 21, which came into focus on Tuesday, said the construction map of the mosque had not been approved.

"With the Uttar Pradesh election approaching in the

next five months, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government is likely to escalate this assault on such structures under the pretext of addressing encroachments. These actions are intended to polarise society along religious lines for electoral gain," said Afzal Ansari, Lok Sabha MP from Ghazipur and a senior leader Samajwadi Party (SP) leader, calling upon the Supreme Court and High Court to take notice of this "motivat-

ed" demolition initiative.

The Congress accused the U.P. government of attempting to instil a sense of "everyday communalism" in the society through such notices. "Development authorities were constituted in Uttar Pradesh after the 1980s... these religious structures are over 100 years old, when no such regulations existed. Structures associated with other communities will also fail the yardstick of the new regulatory framework, but

those linked with the Muslim community are being singled out," said Shahna-waz Alam, Congress national secretary.

'One-point programme'
Zia ur Rehman Barq, the SP MP from Sambhal, accused the Uttar Pradesh government of pursuing a "one-point programme" focused on mosques, madrasas and graveyards, and criticised officials over the demolition of the mosque in Saharanpur. He alleged that the government was not focusing on inflation, employment, education, health care or services for the poor, and was instead "harrassing Muslims" in the belief that it would help it win elections.

Mr. Barq said the Saharanpur mosque was 119 years old and had documents relating to it. He also criticised notices being issued in Sambhal and Moradabad, calling such action "completely wrong".

Ruling alliance led by TVK gets formal title in Tamil Nadu

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The post-poll alliance led by the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) in Tamil Nadu, comprising the Congress, the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), the Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK), and the Marumalarchi Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (MDMK), has been named the Secular Social Justice Victory Alliance (SSJVA).

At the second meeting of the alliance partners at the TVK headquarters in Panaiyur on the outskirts of Chennai on Wednesday, the alliance was formally given the name.

TVK president and Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has been named the chairperson of the alliance. It has been decided that the alliance partners will work together both in Tamil Nadu and Puducherry.

Year-long overhaul boosts Haryana Congress, but challenges persist

NEWS ANALYSIS

Ashok Kumar
GURUGRAM



Haryana Congress chief Rao Narender Singh (left) and State in-charge Sanjay Dutt at a meeting. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

When Indian Youth Congress and National Students' Union of India (NSUI) workers blocked Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini's convoy over Gurugram University's infrastructure last month, the friction signalled a newly coordinated grassroots mobilisation reflecting the results of the party's year-long Sangathan Srijan Abhiyan campaign.

However, this newfound ground momentum remains shadowed by questions being raised on appointments made on recommendations and not entirely on merit, caste equations not being taken care of, and deficit in fe-

male representation at the district level.

The August 21 arrest of eight workers and the subsequent August 25 protest led by Haryana Pradesh Congress Committee president Rao Narender Singh directly stem from an intensive overhaul to rebuild the State Congress's grassroots organisation – a structure that had re-

mained completely dysfunctional for more than a decade.

The party launched the Sangathan Srijan Abhiyan to correct its course after three consecutive Assembly defeats and years of internal factionalism.

Regular dialogue
The organisational overhaul is being accompanied

by an attempt to bring greater accountability into the party with the leadership seeking regular dialogue between senior leaders and grassroots workers, periodic evaluation of office-bearers' performance, and a formal system of monitoring.

The party has simultaneously introduced a performance-based grading system.

"Soon after Sanjay Dutt took over as State in-charge in June, a meeting of all senior leaders from across the State – MPs, MLAs and district presidents – was held. It was followed by interaction with district executive members and active workers in each Assembly to seek their feedback under the 'Samvad' programme," the Haryana Congress chief told *The Hindu*.

The outreach has covered 78 of Haryana's 90 Assembly constituencies, he said.

Issues remain

The effort has begun to change the mood among the rank and file, according to party workers. "The mood is upbeat. It is after a gap of several years that the party's State leadership has turned towards the grassroots workers to interact with them and seek their feedback," said Raju Maan, national convener of the All India Kisan Congress.

Former Hissar MP Brijendra Singh said the Congress organisation was finally taking shape after 12 years, with party activities now more visible across the State and districts, and the Youth Congress and NSUI being activated.

Mr. Maan cautioned that appointments are based on recommendations of senior leaders rather than merit. For instance, Charkhi Dabri, where all four block presidents are Jats and are allegedly aligned with different senior leaders.

"The Congress's central challenge in Haryana was to ensure that it was not seen as a party representing a particular caste," said Lal Bahadur Khowal, chairman of the Haryana Congress Legal Department.

The imbalance in women's representation is another concern. Of the 33 district presidents, only one is a woman – a gap that assumes significance as women have emerged as an increasingly important electoral constituency being courted by all political parties.

HC raps Palghar police for lax investigation in hospital attack case

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The Bombay High Court on Wednesday rapped Palghar police over laxity in probing the case against Shiv Sena workers for assault on medical staff and vandalising a private hospital in the district.

A Bench comprising Justices A.S. Gadkari and Kamal Khata was hearing a suo motu case over allegations that the police have failed to carry out a proper investigation in the case.

Nine absconding

A day earlier, the HC had summoned Palghar Superintendent of Police Yatish Deshmukh over allegations

of inaction. Mr. Deshmukh informed the court that among the 10 accused named in the FIR, Shiv Sena city chief Rahul Gharat has been arrested, while the remaining are absconding.

Calling the police action "unacceptable", the HC observed that police have failed to learn from the previous incident in July where a doctor was assaulted in Thane district's Dombivli public hospital.

The Palghar doctor assault case and Thane case have one thing in common – in both incidents, Shiv Sena office-bearers have been the accused. Sena corporator Ramesh Mhatre was arrested in the Thane case.



Ahead of extradition, idol theft accused to be handed to Centre

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

International antiques dealer Subash Chandra Kapoor, who is in a Tiruchi jail in Tamil Nadu for idol theft, is likely to be handed over to the Union government authorities soon, following an order of the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court to repatriate him to Germany, sources said.

Kapoor, who has been accused of involvement in a number of idol theft cases in the State as well as in other countries, is a U.S. citizen. He was extradited from Germany to India in 2012 in connection with a case registered by the Udayarpalayam police in 2008 over the theft of 19 idols from a temple. As part of the extradition process, India had assured Germany that Kapoor would not be prosecuted in any case other than the one for which he was extradited, without Germany's consent.

Multiple cases

He was convicted in that case by the Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate, Kumbakonam, in November 2022 and sentenced to 10 years' imprisonment. After taking into account the period already spent in custody, he completed his sentence and was due for release in February 2023. However, he was subsequently arrested by the Idol Wing CID in four other cases and continued to remain lodged in the Central Prison at Tiruchi.



Subash Chandra Kapoor

Germany and the U.S. had also sought his extradition in connection with cases pending against him in those countries.

In December last year, Kapoor filed a *habeas corpus* petition before the Madurai Bench, contending that his continued detention in other cases without Germany's consent violated the Extradition Treaty between India and Germany.

Meanwhile, the Union government sought to take custody of Kapoor and produce him before the Extradition Court in Patiala House, New Delhi. The High Court held that his continued detention was without authority of law and could not be sustained in the absence of the consent of the requested State, as required under the Extradition Act, 1962, and the Extradition Treaty. The court directed the Union government to take custody of Kapoor from the Central Prison, Tiruchi, within two weeks and proceed in accordance with law to return him to Germany.

Kapoor's advocate A. Manoj Kumar said his client would now be repatriated to Germany.

ED searches premises linked to Jarkiholi, his MP daughter

Agency examining Karnataka PWD Minister's overseas investment, business ventures; searches unrelated to the alleged corruption in Excise department; new case registered against Jarkiholi

The Hindu Bureau
BELAGAVI/BENGALURU

The Directorate of Enforcement (ED) on Wednesday began conducting searches at the residences and other premises linked to Karnataka Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Satish Jarkiholi and his daughter Priyanka Jarkiholi, who is a Congress MP from the Chikkodi Lok Sabha constituency.

The ED clarified that the latest searches against the Jarkiholis are not related to its searches in June over alleged corruption in the Excise Department, but is an independent new case



Under the scanner: Searches are being carried out at 18 locations, including Bengaluru, Belagavi and Gokak. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

against the PWD Minister. There is no clarity as to whether the searches are being carried out under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002 or the Foreign Exchange Management Act, 1999, the two

laws under which the ED can probe.

The Minister's alleged overseas investment, and his business ventures are being examined, an officer said.

When last checked be-

fore going to print on Wednesday night, the searches were still on. ED sources said they have registered a case against Mr. Jarkiholi.

The searches are being carried out at their residences in Bengaluru, Belagavi, and Gokak, apart from other places. Eighteen locations, including houses of family members, associates, and businesses linked to the Jarkiholi family, are also being searched.

In June this year, the agency claimed that an "organised syndicate involving public officials, intermediaries and private individuals are engaged in systematic collection and distribution of bribes".

ED move in CMRL case 'shameful': Vijayan

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Leader of the Opposition in Keralam Pinarayi Vijayan on Wednesday struck a defiant tone as the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) government "actively reviews" the Enforcement Directorate's (ED) demand to incriminate him, his daughter T. Veena and son-in-law and former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas, in what has come to be known as the CMRL-Exalogic "pay-off" case.

Speaking at the inauguration of the Communist

The agency has asked Kerala Police Chief to register a case against him, family under PCA

Party of India (Marxist)'s [CPI(M)] local committee office at Mannar in Alappuzha, Mr. Vijayan termed the ED's request to the State Police Chief (SPC) to register a case against him and his family under the Prevention of Corruption Act (PCA) as a "shameful" subversion of the criminal justice system for political ends.

"...the ED is attempting a new tack to achieve the political aim of its controllers and those who play second fiddle to its masters by sending a brazenly false set of accusations, masked as a report, to the State's law enforcement to implicate me in a corruption case," he said.

The former Chief Minister also sought to defend his daughter, who is at the centre of the controversy.

The ED had accused Ms. Veena's now-defunct firm, Exalogic Solutions, a software consultancy, of receiving sizeable amounts of money from the CMRL,

a company in which the government has a minority stake, allegedly without providing any tangible service during the 2017-2021 period.

Meanwhile, at a press conference on Wednesday, Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said that the State government will take an appropriate decision after a legal scrutiny of the allegations raised by the ED in its detailed report to the SPC.

"Major" allegations have been raised in the letter seeking the registration of a separate FIR under the PCA in the case, said Mr. Satheesan.

Seat of power

The massive complex will house Tamil Nadu's Legislative Assembly and the Secretariat

Total land area
25.55 acres

Building area
20 lakh sq.ft.

Estimated cost
₹1,200 crore



T.N. to build new Secretariat complex at Pattinapakkam

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government has issued an order giving in-principle approval for initiating the process of constructing a new building complex comprising the Legislative Assembly and Secretariat at Pattinapakkam (Foreshore Estate) in Chennai on an aggregate 25.55 acres of land.

The State government also directed the Public Works Department to submit the Detailed Project Report (DPR), along with estimates, within three months.

On September 3, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay announced in the Assembly the government's plan to construct a new integrated Secretariat complex in Chennai, spread over 20 lakh sq.ft., at an estimated cost of ₹1,200 crore. At present, the Tamil Nadu

Legislative Assembly and Secretariat are functioning on the historical Fort St. George campus.

According to the G.O. issued by the Public Department, the State government has identified 21.76 acres of land under the possession of the Tamil Nadu Housing Board, 0.93 acres of Greater Chennai Corporation land, 1.73 acres of Revenue Department land, and 1.13 acres of Tamil Nadu Housing Board land under the possession of the State government at Foreshore Estate.

The State also constituted three committees - a committee to call for Expressions of Interest and finalise the architectural consultancy firm; a committee to finalise building drawings and designs at the preliminary design stage; and a committee to finalise building drawings and designs at the final design stage, the order said.

INBRIEF



Over 20 BRS MLAs suspended for rest of Monsoon Session

Over 20 members of the Bharat Rashtira Samithi (BRS) were suspended from the Telangana Assembly for the rest of the Monsoon Session. Speaker G. Prasad Kumar announced the decision following a motion moved by Minister D. Sridhar Babu on Wednesday. The Minister moved the motion amid din created by the BRS leaders who thronged the Speaker's Podium. They were agitated over claims by some Congress legislators that they wanted the BRS chief dead. Appeals by the Chair and Mr. Babu to the BRS members to get back to their seats went in vain. With the BRS members sticking to their stand for more than half an hour, Mr. Babu moved the motion to suspend the agitated members.

'Karnataka to challenge CWMA order before SC'

Karnataka is preparing to file a petition before the Supreme Court on Thursday challenging the Cauvery Water Management Authority's (CWMA) direction to release water to Tamil Nadu, according to the State Water Resources Minister N. Cheluvarayaswamy. The Minister said that the decision had been taken after holding detailed deliberations with the Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar. The State will file a review petition before the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee seeking review of its Tuesday's order, he said.

TTD to provide ₹2 lakh life insurance cover for pilgrims

In a first-of-its-kind initiative in the country, the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD) Board on Wednesday approved a ₹2 lakh life insurance cover for pilgrims who die of natural causes in Tirumala, with the amount to be paid to their families. The Board also approved an increase in the insurance for families of TTD devotees who die in accidents in Tirumala, raising the compensation from ₹3 lakh to ₹10 lakh.

Another pregnant woman ferried by bullock cart to ambulance in Telangana

Abhinav Deshpande
HYDERABAD

An ambulance was available, but the road was not. A pregnant woman in Telangana's Kumuram Bheem Asifabad district had to be ferried on a bullock cart to reach a 108-ambulance stranded a few kilometres away.

Karishma, a resident of Sarkepalli in Wankidi mandal, bordering Maharashtra, went into labour on September 5. Her family contacted the 108 emergency ambulance service, but the vehicle could not reach the hamlet as the road had become muddy and difficult to negotiate following rain. With no

A 108-ambulance could not reach her hamlet as the road had become muddy following rain

other way left, her family arranged a bullock cart and transported her across the difficult stretch to where the ambulance was waiting. Ms. Karishma was then taken to Wankidi Government Hospital, where she delivered a baby girl.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Collector K. Haritha said some remote habitations become temporarily inaccessible to motor vehicles during the monsoon.

"We actively monitor

pregnant women based on their estimated date of delivery and get them to the PHC well in advance during the monsoon. But sometimes things come up unexpectedly..." Ms. Haritha said.

The latest incident is not the first instance of a pregnant woman in the tribal district having to depend on a bullock cart.

In August 2024, a woman from another remote habitation in the district was reportedly transported on a bullock cart after a 108-ambulance could not reach her village. She was carried for about 2.5 km before reaching the ambulance. She subsequently lost her unborn child.

G. Krishnakumar
KOCHI

A pollution risk assessment by the International Tanker Owners Pollution Federation (ITOPF) on the containers that fell into the sea after a fire aboard the Singapore-flagged vessel *Wan Hai 503* off the Kerala coast on June 9, 2025, has stated that some shoreline impacts may be experienced in the future "due to corrosion of the container or loss of integrity of the packaging (likely to be in decades)".

"At this time, ITOPF considers that these cargoes do not pose a significant risk to the marine environment," said the



Singapore-flagged *Wan Hai 503* that caught fire off the Kerala coast on June 9, 2025.

container risk assessment report submitted by the vessel's registered owner before the National Green Tribunal (NGT).

The Southern Bench, which took *suo motu* cognisance of the report, *Container vessel on fire off Kerala coast*, published in *The*

Hindu, had asked the owners to submit a report with details of the cargo and its environmental impact.

The vessel was carrying approximately 1,754 containers at the time of the incident. It was subsequently towed to the port of Jebel Ali in the UAE in August 24, 2025. The registered owners had entrusted the ITOPF, an organisation funded by the global shipping industry, with preparing a container risk assessment in compliance with the tribunal's directive.

The report said the containers had a wide range of products, categorised as miscellaneous goods, plastic resins and pellets, food, and inorganic chemicals.

DMK candidates announced for two T.N. Assembly bypolls

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK president M.K. Stalin on Wednesday announced his party's candidates for the bypolls to be held in Madurantakam and Dharapuram Assembly constituencies on October 6.

Party's legal wing deputy secretary I. Paranthamen, who previously served as the MLA for Egmore constituency, has been fielded in Madurantakam (Chengalpattu district), while S. Suganya, an advocate and member of the DMK Women's Wing, is the candidate for Dharapuram (Tiruppur district).

Both the reserved constituencies fell vacant following the resignation of AIADMK legislators Maragatham Kumaravel (Madurantakam) and P. Sathyabama (Dharapuram), who later joined the ruling TVK.

Puducherry candidate

The DMK has declared K. Sethu Selvam as party candidate for the bypoll in Thattanchavady constituency in Puducherry.

Mr. Selvam, a former member of the Communist Party of India (CPI), had met Mr. Stalin on Wednesday at Chennai before his candidature was announced.

Duo stuck in Keralam forest after filming *Neelakurinji* rescued in night operation

The Hindu Bureau
PALAKKAD

Two youth who entered the Attappady forest in Palakkad district of Keralam to film *Neelakurinji* blooms for their social media handles got lost in the dense jungle, prompting a risky late-night search operation by forest staff.

Abheendar and Shanu, both aged 23, entered the protected Chenthamala reserve forest without permission on Tuesday morning. They hiked for over three hours before reaching a high-altitude area. While returning, they lost their way. Darkness fell before they could find their way out. They then alerted



Forest department staff pose with the two youth rescued from the Attappady forest on Wednesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

their family members who contacted forest officials around 8 p.m.

A forest team launched a search, carrying water and biscuits for the youth. It trekked for about three-and-a-half hours and found the duo around 11.30 p.m. "They were tired. One had

muscle cramps," said N. Safer, Attappady range Forest Officer, who supervised the operation.

However, the team had a few more obstacles to overcome before the journey was over. On their way back, they encountered elephants many times and

had to step away to avoid confrontation. Eventually, the team came out of the forest early on Wednesday.

Chenthamala has a high presence of elephants and other wild animals. Weather here also changes quickly, Mr. Safer said.

Case filed against youth

The Forest department filed a case against the duo for trespassing into the forest. Forest staff summoned their parents and explained the risks involved.

The famed *Neelakurinji* had bloomed in the area about three weeks ago. The department had warned people not to enter the forest owing to the risks.

8 multi-tracking projects receive Cabinet approval

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA), chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on Wednesday approved eight projects of the Ministry of Railways with a total cost of ₹20,804 crore.

Of the eight projects, there are five multi-tracking projects of the Arakkonam-Renigunta third and fourth lines covering 77 km, Whitefield-Bangarapet third and fourth lines covering 47 km, Hosur-Omarur line doubling spanning 147 km, Salem-Karur-Dindigul doubling covering 159 km, multi-tracking of Secunderabad (Ghatkesar)-Kazipet for 110 km, across Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, and Telangana.

The first five projects, covering 17 districts across the four States, will enhance connectivity to approximately 2,121 villages having a population of about 52 lakh.

“These projects are essential routes for transportation of commodities such as coal, cement, iron and steel, containers, automobiles, food grains, petroleum products, etc.,” a statement from the Ministry of Railways stated.

The capacity augmentation works will result in ad-



The tracks will help in the transportation of essential commodities.

ditional freight traffic of 47 MTPA (million tonnes per annum).

The other three projects, including Kharagpur-Jharsuguda (Bagdehi) fourth Line, Katni-Pendra Road fourth line and Bilaspur (Uslapur)-Pendra Road third line, will span across West Bengal, Jharkhand, Odisha, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh.

The latter three projects will enhance connectivity to nearly 4,790 villages, which have a population of about 56 lakh.

These eight projects will increase the existing network of the Indian Railways by 1,196 km. The projects are planned under the PM-Gati Shakti National Master Plan, with a focus on enhancing multi-modal connectivity and logistics efficiency through integrated planning.

Ex-officials flag concerns over Census data quality, potential NPR, NRC link

While records show Census data was used to prepare NRC in 1951, former senior official says such data is confidential and can only be used for statistical purposes; advancing Census in 4 States may lead to under-enumeration of migrants, he adds

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The Union government’s decision to advance the Population Enumeration phase of Census 2027 in four poll-bound States, coupled with the introduction of several new questions in the Census schedule, has prompted some former Census officials to raise concerns regarding the quality of data that is to be collected and the potential links between the Census, the National Population Register (NPR) and, ultimately, the National Register of Citizens (NRC).

There is a precedent for Census data having been used to prepare the NRC. Records show that this took place in 1951, during Independent India’s first Census, when the NRC was prepared across the country by “copying” data from the Census schedules. However, for unspecified reasons, a countrywide NRC was never published, except in undivided Assam, which at the time also included Manipur and Tripura.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, former Deputy Registrar General of India K. Narayanan Unni stressed that any link between the Census



Keeping track: A final updated NRC list, after a long exercise, was published for Assam on August 31, 2019. FILE PHOTO

and population-registration activities remains speculative. However, some of the information being sought in the latest Census questionnaire resembled data collected during previous NPR update exercises.

The NPR, first created in 2011 and initially proposed to be updated with the first phase of the now-scrapped Census 2021, has been put on the back burner due to stiff opposition from political parties and civil society groups.

Mr. Unni said, “NPR is generated under the Citizenship Act, and data is supposed to be published. However, Census data is confidential and can only be used for statistical purposes. But in 1951, Census

data was used to prepare the NRC in Assam...”

On August 14, 2026, the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India (RG&CCI) notified a set of 40 questions to be asked during the Population Enumeration phase of the Census.

Some of the additional questions, such as particulars of a person’s parents, including their names, religion, place of birth, Aadhaar, mobile phone number, voter ID and driving licence details, mirror those asked in the rehearsed form of the NPR in 2019.

The 1951 exercise

The NPR had been updated in 2015 and already has the family-wise database of 119 crore residents.

data to prepare the register.

A former Census official, speaking on the condition of anonymity, said the NPR and the Census were legally distinct exercises governed by different laws. The official pointed out that the update of the NRC in Assam in 2019 was not based on NPR data and required a separate data collection exercise.

On September 5, the RG&CCI advanced the Population Enumeration phase of Census 2027 in the poll-bound States of Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Uttarakhand and Goa, while deferring the exercise in violence-hit Manipur.

Mr. Unni said that the decision to conduct the Census in four States ahead of the rest of the country could lead to under-enumeration of migrant workers, particularly from Uttar Pradesh.

Mr. Unni also questioned the utility of some of the new questions, particularly those relating to identity documents and vaccination history.

“Many of these details are already available in administrative databases. It is not clear what statistical purpose some of these questions will serve,” he said.

Five rescued after iron slab collapses in Gandhinagar

Press Trust of India
AHMEDABAD

At least five workers were rescued from the debris after a huge iron slab collapsed at a construction site in the Kudasan area in Gandhinagar on Wednesday night, officials said.

The accident took place around 9 p.m. at a building under construction when an iron slab being erected between two buildings suddenly collapsed, trapping workers underneath.

According to the Gandhinagar police control room, firefighters, police and the local administration were carrying out rescue operations at the site as labourers claimed that several persons were working on the metal structure and might have been trapped in the debris.

More than four fire brigades rushed to the spot after being alerted about the incident and launched a rescue operation.

Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi reached the site and supervised the rescue operation.

Health Minister Praful Pansheriya said the five injured workers had been shifted to Gandhinagar Civil Hospital.

The exact number of workers trapped under the collapsed structure was not immediately clear, officials said.

Over 4,000 govt. schools submerged across 14 flood-hit districts in Bihar

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

In Bihar, 514 village panchayats in 84 blocks across 14 districts were reeling under floods on Wednesday, with the Ganga, Gandak, Kosi, Punpun, Bagmati and Ghagra rivers flowing above the danger mark in several places, even as water levels began falling at some locations.

Over 4,000 government schools have been submerged in the 14 flood-hit districts, with the schooling of over three lakh students likely to be severely affected.

The Bihar Education Department recently announced half-yearly exams for Classes 1 to 12 to be held from September 15, 2026.



People from the Bind Tola area use a makeshift boat to move through a flood-affected area in Patna on Wednesday. PTI

Students rued that not even a third of the syllabus has been completed yet due to the floods, and other reasons, including the lack of teachers and their transfers.

The Education Department has also asked stu-

dents to bring their own mats and polythene sheets for the exams to be held in village panchayat buildings and open spaces in their respective areas.

“This came as an utter surprise for us. When even the course syllabus is not

completed by the teachers due to the floods, how can the department ask students to bring mats and polythene sheets from home for the exam?” Harishankar Mandal of Naugachhia in Bhagalpur district, whose son is a Class 12 student, said. Subodh Mandal is a student at a government school that has been flooded with waist-deep water for the past 10 days, during which classes have been suspended. Students and parents of other submerged schools echoed this view.

Necessary directions have been provided for flood-hit areas so that students’ academic preparations are not hampered, Bihar Education Minister Mithilesh Tiwari said.

Pollution from open waste burning triples in cities during winter: study

Jacob P. Koshy
NEW DELHI

Open waste burning rises sharply in winter across different categories of Indian cities, with the average incidence, quantity of waste burned, and associated emissions as much as three times higher than in summer, according to a working paper by the World Resources Institute (WRI) India.

The findings come as cities approach the post-monsoon period, when falling temperatures and stagnant atmospheric conditions typically make it harder for pollutants to disperse.

The study, based on field surveys from 2019-2026 in 11 polluted Indian



Tier 3 cities recorded the highest incidence of open waste burning in winter, among the cities examined. FILE PHOTO

cities, the names of which have not been disclosed, found that Tier 2 cities, with their population between 500,000 and five million, had the highest quantities of waste burned among the cities examined.

Tier 3 cities, however,

recorded the highest winter incidence of burning, at an average of 49.6 incidents per square kilometre per day, compared with 46 in Tier 2 cities, and 39.4 in Tier 1 cities.

Open waste burning was not the dominant source of citywide particu-

late pollution, and contributed less than 1% of total citywide PM2.5 and PM10 emissions in the cities assessed. But because it happens closer to homes, streets and waste dumps, it can increase short-term exposure to toxic smoke.

The burden, the report assessed, was also strongly associated with socio-economic conditions. Poorer areas recorded substantially more burning than higher-income areas, with the highest incidence in the study, at nearly 84 incidents per square kilometre per day, recorded in the poorer areas of Tier 2 cities during winter. The researchers say the pattern points to disparities in waste collection and other municipal services.

Last rites held for Manipur musician killed in Delhi

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The last rites of Manipur musician Chongtham Vikram Singh were performed at his locality in the State’s capital, Imphal, on Wednesday, amid calls for swift action against his killers.

The body of the musician, who died after an alleged assault in Delhi’s Sunlight Colony on Monday, was flown to Imphal in the morning. Hundreds gathered at the airport to receive the body, which was taken to the family residence in Thangmeiband Lourungpule.

Several people broke down when Vikram’s mortal remains were brought home.

Chongtham Vivek Singh, the slain musician’s brother, said the death had caused deep grief to people across Manipur.



Seeking answers: A vehicle displays banners calling for justice for Chongtham Vikram in Imphal on Wednesday. PTI

“This is a very sad and painful moment for everyone in the State. His death is not only a loss for our family but also for the entire music fraternity,” he said, demanding strict punishment for those responsible for his brother’s death. He also urged the Delhi authorities to ensure that the investigation and

legal proceedings are completed swiftly.

Vikram’s death also intensified calls for a law against racism, believed to be the prime reason behind attacks – lethal at times – against people from the northeastern region in “mainland India”, specifically the metropolitan cities.

‘Data on proposals for de-reservation not readily available’

Abhinay Lakshman
NEW DELHI

The Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) has said that it does not have “readily available” data on the number of de-reservation proposals it had received from various Ministries and departments of the Union government over the last six years.

De-reservation is the practice of filling a reserved position with a general category candidate.

The DoPT clarification comes amid a recent complaint from the National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC) that the Centre’s de-reservation proposals were often incomplete and did not reveal alternative efforts made to fill reserved vacancies. The NCSC had, therefore, decided to

launch a probe into such proposals, to ensure effective implementation of the reservation policy.

According to regulations for government recruitment issued by the DoPT, there is a general ban on de-reserving posts, with very specific exceptions.

In response to queries from *The Hindu* under the Right to Information Act of 2005, the DoPT cited Section 7(9) of the law to say that gathering the information on de-reservation proposals would “disproportionately divert the resources of the public authority”. It went on to say, “Information required may be scattered with many departments/Ministries,” adding that the law does not mandate the concerned information officer to “create or interpret” information.

Govt. may challenge ruling on NSA detention, says S-G

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta on Wednesday orally indicated the government’s intent to challenge an Allahabad High Court decision to quash an order of the Gautam Buddha Nagar District Magistrate, Medha Roopam, detaining a 25-year-old Delhi University law student under the National Security Act (NSA) over a workers’ protest in Noida in April this year.

Mr. Mehta made a remark to this extent while making an oral mention in connection with a separate case concerning a show-cause notice issued by an Executive Magistrate, Greater Noida Commissionerate, to a student in connection with the NEET-UG paper leaks protests.

A High Court Division Bench headed by Justice

Atul Sreedharan had quashed the NSA detention of Akriti Chaudhary in a September 2 order while deriding Ms. Roopam’s lack of application of mind to a police report against the student activist, who had spent nearly five months in custody.

The Bench had allowed Ms. Chaudhary’s *habeas corpus* petition and ordered her immediate release, unless she was required in another case. The court flagged discrepancies in the arrest notice and termed the State’s version a “concocted story”.

Ms. Chaudhary was among several activists arrested in connection with the protest held between April 10 and 18, during which industrial and contractual workers demanded a hike in salary and parity with wages paid in neighbouring Haryana.

The protest had turned violent on April 13.

The Uttar Pradesh Police invoked the NSA against Ms. Chaudhary a month later, alleging that she had instigated protesters to indulge in pelting stones and arson.

During a press conference, the police claimed to have “strong electronic and videographic evidence” against her.

The High Court had directed that Ms. Chaudhary be paid compensation of ₹5 lakh, and that the amount be recovered from the salaries of the District Magistrate and “all such other officers who may have been responsible, right down to the Station House Officer” of the police station, who had prepared the initial report warranting the detention of the petitioner under the provisions of the NSA.

MHA proposes new Chapter ‘K’ under Article 371 for Ladakh

Provision being made to bring elected body for Union Territory; civil society members who attended MHA meet say they were ‘disappointed’ as they are yet to receive draft proposal; they also sought compensation for families of violence victims

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has proposed an elected body for the Union Territory (UT) of Ladakh by introducing a new constitutional provision under Article 371 of the Constitution in a proposed Chapter K, civil society members who attended a meeting with MHA officials in Delhi on Wednesday said.

Cherring Dorjay Lakruk of the Leh Apex Body (LAB) told *The Hindu* that they were “disappointed” as this was a reiteration of the May 22 meeting, and were given a PowerPoint presentation mentioning Chapter K on Wednesday but were yet to get a detailed “draft proposal” from the MHA.

A statement released by the civil society members said, “The MHA stated that the intended UT-level body, would be elected by di-



Making a point: People from Ladakh have staged several protests over the years seeking Statehood. ANI

rect election, and would have legislative powers with respect to land, culture and language, forest, environment, natural resources, and any other subject matter reserved for the UT under Article 240.”

Ladakh chief secretary Ashish Kundra, who attended the meeting, said in a post on X, “Attended the sub-committee meeting with leaders of Ladakh at MHA in Delhi today. A general air of positivity prevailed as the broad con-

tours of a Sui-generis model of governance under Article 371 of the Constitution were discussed. Deepening democracy is the goal.”

Representatives of the LAB and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) asked the MHA to ensure that the Lieutenant-Governor of Ladakh does not take any major decisions concerning the administration, bureaucracy or land until the proposed constitutional safeguards are put in place,

while pressing for the legislation to be passed in the upcoming Winter Session of Parliament.

The members also sought compensation for the families of the victims of the violence that broke out on September 24, 2025, in Leh city, where four people were killed in police firing. They further sought the withdrawal of criminal cases against 80 people, along the lines of the protection afforded to those who took part in the “Gen Z protest” at Delhi’s Jantar Mantar in July. The violence in Ladakh erupted amid a protest that was called to demand constitutional safeguards.

Article 371, which currently has chapters that run from A to J, deals with “Temporary, Transitional and Special Provisions” and exists under Part XXI of the Constitution. It is currently applicable in 12 States: Nagaland, Assam, Manipur, Mizoram, Maharashtra, Gujarat, Andhra

Pradesh, Telangana, Arunachal Pradesh, Goa, Sikkim, and Karnataka.

After Ladakh lost its special status under Article 370 of the Constitution as part of the erstwhile State of Jammu and Kashmir, it was turned into a Union Territory without a legislative assembly in 2019. Since then, the LAB and the KDA have been demanding Statehood and tribal status for Ladakh and seeking a larger role for local residents in decisions relating to land and infrastructure projects.

Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk, who was also part of the delegation that met MHA officials, said, “We cannot say that the meeting was a complete success. We hoped to get a draft proposal assuring us protection under Article 371. However, that was not provided. We have asked the government to take back the cases registered against protesters after last year’s incident in Leh city.”

Cong. alleges ₹10,000-cr. tax evasion through ‘bogus’ political parties, seeks JPC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Alleging that 3,260 registered unrecognised political parties (RUPPs) had received political donations and evaded income tax to the tune of ₹10,000 crore, the Congress on Wednesday demanded a Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) probe into the “donation scam”.

Addressing a press conference here, Congress MP Shaktisinh Gohil alleged that the parties were being used as a route to convert unaccounted-for money into legitimate political donations by way of round-tripping and other means.

Party general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh later alleged that the 3,260 parties were operating under the “patronage” of the BJP. “Who is the ‘Chanakya’ behind these 3,260 sham political parties and who is the true mastermind of this scam?” Mr. Ramesh asked on X.



Shaktisinh Gohil

He also contrasted the alleged tax evasion with the Congress’s experience before the 2024 Lok Sabha election, when its bank accounts were frozen and it received tax notices. “So, why is there no investigation into these 3,260 sham political parties and the associated cases of tax evasion,” Mr. Ramesh asked.

The Congress said the Income Tax Act provides tax benefits on donations to registered political parties. These provisions were being misused through the RUPPs, it said.

Mr. Gohil said the government should investigate the parties and the people who donated to them. Under the Income Tax Act, a penalty of 200% can be

imposed on those found guilty, and criminal proceedings initiated against individuals and chartered accountants involved in wrongdoing, he said.

He also demanded that the licences of chartered accountants found guilty be cancelled and that criminal cases be filed against those running the alleged bogus political parties.

Public disclosure

The Congress further sought public disclosure of details of donations received by bogus political parties, as well as information on those people linked to the parties who later joined the BJP.

Mr. Gohil alleged that no action had been taken against even one person despite the alleged tax evasion exceeding ₹10,000 crore. “Officials had recommended action against those involved but that orders had not come from the “top”, he added

He also questioned the Election Commission’s role in scrutinising the funding.

Rahul’s ‘Goonj’ impact won’t extend beyond Congress workers: Nabin

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Bharatiya Janata Party president Nitin Nabin on Wednesday targeted Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi over his “*Chhatron ki Goonj*” programme series, claiming that its impact would not extend beyond his party workers.

“Those who are trying to misdirect the voices of children...if there had been strength in their own voices, when they had the opportunity, they would have done something for the youth of this country,” said Mr. Nabin in response to a question at a press conference. He said: “Under the leadership of Narendra Modi, today’s youth is moving forward by becoming self-reliant.”



Nitin Nabin

Attacking the Congress over its recent decision to sing only two stanzas of *Vande Mataram* at party events, Mr. Nabin described the party as having an “anarchic” and “anti-national” mindset.

25 years of Modi

October 7 will mark 25 years since Mr. Modi began his public-service career as Gujarat Chief Minister. Mr. Nabin said the party was therefore holding a month-long “*Seva Sankalp Abhi-*

yan” from September 17 to October 17. The campaign’s purpose was to take to every person the changes brought by him during this period, ranging from good governance and welfare schemes, to strengthening the resolve of “Viksit Bharat 2047”, he said.

Listing the achievements of the Modi government, he said 25 crore poor families were lifted out of poverty; 80 crore people provided ration; over 100 crore connected to social security schemes; 200 crore free COVID vaccines administered; houses given to over four crore poor people, etc. The country’s international standing increased; the internal and external security was strengthened, and strong steps taken to eliminate Naxalism, he said.

Mr. Nabin said the go-

vernment bolstered the country’s cultural identity through various projects; encouraged self-reliance across sectors; and launched major youth employment-oriented initiatives. Emphasis was being given to “women-led development” and securing women’s rights.

He said the BJP’s campaigns were not responses to Opposition programmes. They were based on the party’s ideology, vision, and manifesto, and with the goal to unite the country’s citizens.

Alleging “anarchy and corruption” in Punjab, Mr. Nabin said the party would take those issues to coming polls. He said there was a need for a larger public movement against drugs in the State and the BJP intended to build such a campaign.

In Rahul case, CJI says all parties are treated equally

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Wednesday said that “all parties are treated equally” in the Supreme Court after senior advocate and BJP spokesperson Gaurav Bhatia, appearing for a complainant in a defamation case against Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, alleged that the Opposition leader’s matter is being repeatedly adjourned.

The exchange happened during an oral mentioning by Mr. Bhatia to tag Mr. Gandhi’s plea against criminal proceedings arising from his alleged remarks concerning the Army and the Chinese attack in the context of the 2020 Galwan clash.

He said the last time the case was listed was in December last year. The top



The top court is hearing a defamation case against Congress leader Rahul Gandhi.

court had scheduled the next hearing on April 22, 2026. However, the case had not been listed until September 9.

Mr. Bhatia alleged the case was not being listed due to the “person mentioned”, and he should not be treated like a “VVIP”.

He said Mr. Gandhi’s side was indulging in “dila-

tory tactics” to avoid a hearing.

Advocate Prasanna S., for Mr. Gandhi, vehemently objected to the submissions made by Mr. Bhatia, saying that such statements should not be permitted to be made in court.

“All parties are treated equally here,” Chief Justice Kant addressed Mr. Bhatia.

The Bench advised Mr. Bhatia to submit an application for de-tagging of the case.

The court had earlier stayed proceedings against Mr. Gandhi in the case based on a complaint filed by a retired Border Roads Organisation (BRO) officer, Uday Shankar Shrivastava, before a Lucknow Magistrate court in August 2023. The Lucknow court had issued summons to the Congress leader in February 2025.

BJD stages protest over Mines and Minerals Amendment Act

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

The Biju Janata Dal staged a massive protest demonstration demanding constitutional intervention for the reversal of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) (MMDR) Amendment Act, 2026 here on Wednesday.

BJD leaders marched towards the Lok Bhavan to apprise Governor Hari Babu Kambhampati of the consequences for Odisha upon the implementation of the Act. They submitted a comprehensive memorandum addressed to President Droupadi Murmu through the Governor.

“Odisha is one of the most mineral-rich states in the country and has contributed immensely to India’s industrial and economic development through its reserves of iron ore, coal, bauxite, chromite, and other minerals. The mineral resources located within the territory of Odisha constitute an important component of the State’s natural wealth and have



Seeking action: Police stopping BJD workers during a protest against the MMDR Amendment Act 2026 in Bhubaneswar. PTI

historically been a major source of revenue for the State government,” the BJD leaders said.

“Any legislative measure that substantially curtails the rights and financial interests of the State in relation to mines and mineral-bearing lands therefore has far-reaching consequences for Odisha and its people, and deserves careful constitutional and legal examination,” the BJD said.

BJD leaders referred to the July 24, 2024 Supreme Court judgment, which recognised the power of State governments to impose taxes and levies on

mines and mineral-bearing lands, and also dealt with the recovery of such dues from the period beginning April 1, 2005. “Odisha became entitled to receive substantial amounts towards arrears of mining-related taxes and levies. It was estimated that the State could receive more than ₹1 lakh crore towards arrears, apart from an additional annual revenue of approximately ₹12,000 crore,” the BJD leaders said.

Following the amendment to the Act, Odisha stood to lose massive sums of the revenue, they said.

CM hits back after Rahul accuses Punjab govt. of crushing those who ask questions

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Wednesday asked the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi not to “do politics over dead bodies” after the Congress leader stepped up his attack on the Aam Aadmi Party government over the alleged death by suicide of a Dalit man, Gulzar Singh.

Mr. Gandhi demanded the resignation of Punjab Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema and an independent probe into the death, alleging that Gulzar had been pressured and humiliated after he had questioned the Minister about the drug menace in his area.

“A dangerous pattern is emerging under Punjab’s AAP government – if you question government’s failures, the response will come in the form of threats and torture,” Mr. Gandhi said in a post on social media platform X.

He alleged that Mr. Singh, whose son had fallen



Rahul Gandhi, left, wants an independent probe into a villager’s death but Bhagwant Mann says the issue should not be politicised.



len victim to drugs, had questioned Mr. Cheema about the government’s failure to stop the drug trade and was subsequently pressured to apologise.

Mr. Gandhi pointed to another alleged instance of harassment as well. “Last week, I also spoke with a young Mohanjeet Singh, who was tortured for protesting against Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann,” Mr. Gandhi said.

Mr. Mohanjeet Singh, who hails from Sangrur district, had alleged that he was tortured in custody after allegedly consuming poison. His family said he had raised slogans against the government’s handling of

the drug menace at a programme attended by Mr. Mann.

“The government’s job is to answer to the people, not to ‘crush’ those who ask questions,” he said, demanding that Mr. Mann immediately seek Mr. Cheema’s resignation and ensure an “independent and impartial investigation”, with the Minister’s name included in the first information report (FIR).

Gulzar Singh, 47, from Dirba in Sangrur district, died on Monday night after allegedly consuming poison. His family said he had questioned Mr. Cheema at an event on September 6

about the availability of drugs, including “*chitta* (heroin)”, in the area.

Mann’s response

Responding to Mr. Gandhi, Mr. Mann said: “Rahul Gandhiji, don’t do politics over dead bodies; Punjabis do not like this kind of politics.”

The Chief Minister said the police had already arrested the accused and alleged that Congress leaders who visited Gulzar’s village had been “chased away” by local persons.

Hitting back, Mr. Gandhi shared video clips of the family members of the deceased in which they blamed AAP functionaries and the Minister. “The people of Punjab, and especially the Dalits, should become vigilant regarding the misuse of power by the AAP government,” he said.

AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal, in a post on X, also accused Mr. Gandhi of indulging in “dirty politics over a dead body”.

(Those in distress can seek help by calling: iCALL 9152987821)

Withdraw stand on Gram Sabha consent, rights group urges Ministry

Abhinav Lakshman
NEW DELHI

The Tribal Affairs Ministry must immediately withdraw its August 31 office memorandum that claimed there was “no provision” under the Forest Rights Act (FRA) to seek consent of Gram Sabhas for diverting forest land for non-forest purposes, the Campaign for Survival and Dignity (CSD) said in a statement on Wednesday.

The national platform of Adivasi and forest-dweller organisations said the Ministry “cannot simply wash its hands of its responsibility”, calling the Ministry’s position “factually and legally untenable”, which “smacks of dereliction of duty”.

“It is completely shocking that the Ministry of Tribal Affairs has made such a gargantuan factual blunder, something which could have been avoided simply by reading the text of the law,” said the CSD.

The statement comes amid criticisms of the Tribal Affairs Ministry’s communication to the Power Ministry, with which it is currently in discussions about how the requirement of 100% Gram Sabha consent for diversion of forest land has become a “critical bottleneck” delaying large government projects, as first reported by *The Hindu*.

‘Shocking stance’

A day earlier, former Environment Minister and Congress leader Jairam Ramesh had also criticised the position of the Tribal Affairs Ministry as a “shocking stance” that went against its own directives, communications, guidelines, and the set procedure under law as it exists today, especially after Supreme Court judgments like the one in the Niyamgiri case.

The CSD echoed the criticism and alleged that the Ministry was taking this position “in order to appease the interests of project developers, contractors and big corporations”.

Garden Reach Shipbuilders and Engineers (GRSE) on Wednesday launched *Sagar Manthan*, an indigenous ocean research vessel being built for the National Centre for Polar and Ocean Research (NCPOR), in a major boost to India's capabilities in deep-sea exploration and scientific research. A top government official said the ₹840-crore research vessel is expected to be ready for use by early 2028. Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Earth Sciences Jitendra Singh congratulated GRSE and the Ministry of Earth Sciences on the launch and naming of the vessel and conveyed his wishes on the occasion. ^{PTI}

The Aam Aadmi Party's (AAP) national council on Wednesday re-elected Arvind Kejriwal as the party's national convener, the highest post in the party, a statement said. The party's 15th national council meeting was held on Wednesday under Mr. Kejriwal's chairmanship and a total of 330 members participated in the meeting. "During the meeting, a new 23-member national executive was constituted. Arvind Kejriwal has once again been unanimously elected as the AAP's national convener. Pankaj Gupta has been elected as the national secretary, while N. D. Gupta will continue as the national treasurer," the statement said.

Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan on Wednesday underlined Arunachal Pradesh's strategic importance to India and said the State was an integral part of the country's unity. Addressing a special session of the State's 60-member Assembly, he said the northeastern State plays a vital role in safeguarding India's borders. Mr. Radhakrishnan also highlighted the nation's diversity. The Vice-President's statement comes as New Delhi flagged "anomalies" in the United Nations' new world map depicting Arunachal Pradesh and Aksai Chin, two integral parts of India, as separate regions positioned between the borders claimed by India and China.

A probe into the alleged terror offences involving six Ukrainian citizens and one U.S. national, who were arrested by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in March on charges of training anti-India armed groups in Myanmar, continues to look into whether they were engaged in activities prejudicial to India's security, government sources said. As per the NIA, the accused persons provided training in drone assembly and operation, drone warfare and jamming technology to members of Myanmar-based ethnic armed groups, including the Chin National Front (CNF) and the Kachin Independence Army (KIA).

A IN-Y



Dangerous phase

The Iran war is plunging the region into an economic and security abyss

The crisis in West Asia is escalating on two fronts. On Tuesday, the U.S. said that its forces had struck five Iranian oil tankers in the Gulf waters after what it claimed were Tehran's attacks on U.S. warships in the region. Iran retaliated with a massive ballistic missile attack on the Muwaffaq Salti U.S. air base in Jordan and vowed to respond with greater force to every U.S. attack from now on. It has also announced a new restricted zone in the Strait of Hormuz, warning commercial ships against crossing it under American naval escort. Separately, Yemen's Houthis, who are closely aligned with Tehran, launched an attack on Saudi Arabia, wounding dozens. Riyadh has vowed a response. The Houthis, who control northern Yemen and parts of its Red Sea coast, have already enforced a naval blockade of Saudi Arabia's western ports and launched an offensive against the forces of Yemen's Saudi-backed government in Taiz and Mocha. With both the Strait of Hormuz, which connects the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman, and the Red Sea, a critical trade channel between Europe and Asia, remaining flashpoints, a horizontally escalating conflict from Tehran to Jordan and Riyadh to Bab-el Mandeb threatens to plunge the entire region into an economic and security abyss.

The current phase of the conflict could prove to be deadlier for several reasons. The U.S., which in the recent past has used intense military strikes and economic strangulation as separate policy tools in an attempt to force Iran to surrender, is now using both simultaneously to exert maximum pressure on Tehran. The U.S. naval blockade has largely prevented Iran from exporting its oil, while the American naval escort to a limited number of ships out of the Strait of Hormuz has helped Washington blunt the impact of Iran's chokehold on the waterway on global energy prices. But President Donald Trump was wrong if he thought his maximum economic and military pressure would force Iran to make concessions. Iran, instead, decided to escalate the conflict by attacking American warships outside the Persian Gulf, fully aware that this would invite a stronger U.S. military response. Iran appears to believe that it has a window of opportunity with the U.S. heading into its midterm elections within weeks and Mr. Trump remaining politically weak at home. If Iran's strikes on U.S. military vessels signal a clear decision at the top to escalate the conflict, its missile attack on U.S. bases in Jordan suggests that Tehran has been rebuilding its strike capabilities – capabilities that Mr. Trump had claimed were destroyed. As neither Washington nor Iran seems ready to step back from the precipice, the war is set to enter a more dangerous phase with global economic implications.

Ray of hope

Courts are coming down on reflexive arrests of activists

The district administration in Noida, Uttar Pradesh, went to great lengths to detain 25-year-old Delhi University law student and activist Akriti Chaudhary on April 11, 2026, in connection with protests by workers in the city. But on September 2, the Allahabad High Court quashed her National Security Act (NSA) detention, terming it an “abuse of the draconian preventive detention law” and came down heavily on the administration. The High Court's intervention is a silver lining in the dark cloud of extreme executive arbitrariness that is smothering the democratic soul of India. It termed the Noida administration's conduct “despotic”, its allegations against the activist a “concocted story”, and noted that the District Magistrate had passed the NSA detention order “without application of mind”. Without mincing words, the High Court warned that an unhinged bureaucracy could reduce the State of Uttar Pradesh to an “Orwellian dystopia”. The Division Bench of Justices Atul Sreedharan and Achal Sachdev ordered compensation of ₹5 lakh for Ms. Chaudhary, which is to be deducted from the salaries of the officers concerned. The facts of the case were brazenly in contradiction with the claims of the police and the district administration, but it also took a rigorous and conscientious Bench to provide this relief. It noted in its order that Ms. Chaudhary was already in the custody of the police when the violence that she is accused of took place.

The relief from the High Court has not set the activist free, as she is named by the U.P. Police in 11 other cases. It will be a long journey of legal battles to get her the freedom that every citizen in a democratic country deserves. That the police would go to such an extent to make life difficult for someone who stood up for the underprivileged must shock the conscience of the nation. Between April 10 and 18, 2026, industrial and contractual workers in Noida had staged protests demanding a wage hike and wage parity with neighbouring Haryana. On April 13, the protests allegedly turned violent. The Noida Police claimed to have “strong electronic and video-graphic evidence” of incitement against Ms. Chaudhary, and it turned out to be merely that, a claim which could not be established. Ms. Chaudhary could receive legal support and media attention that hundreds of others in comparable situations cannot easily access, while the workers remain trapped in miserable conditions because of oppressive business models and state policies that favour capital owners, with the promises made to them still unfulfilled. Yet, the Allahabad High Court's intervention in Ms. Chaudhary's case is a ray of hope that democratic protests will be heeded rather than suppressed by the strong-arm tactics of the executive.

State's development story cannot be the story of its capital alone. Bengaluru is indeed India's pride and the city that has placed Karnataka on the global map. From Information Technology (IT), startups, aerospace and biotechnology to global corporations and new-generation entrepreneurs, Bengaluru has everything that makes it the pillar of India's economy.

But when opportunities are concentrated in one city, so is the pressure. With a population of around 12.5 million and over 11.5 million vehicles, Bengaluru is already facing enormous pressure on its roads, housing and infrastructure. We need to change the pattern of people from rural areas and other cities migrating to Bengaluru in search of opportunities. This is why cities such as Delhi and Mumbai have developed alternative growth centres such as Gurugram and Noida, and Navi Mumbai and Thane, respectively.

The next steps being taken

Karnataka's next chapter cannot depend on one city. It must create several cities and regions that can become strong economic centres in their own right. Taking investments beyond Bengaluru is not an alternative to strengthening Bengaluru; it is, alongside it, an economic strategy for balanced regional development, local employment, new investments, technology and better opportunities across Karnataka. Through Karnataka Digital Economy Mission (KDEM), key clusters including Mysuru, Mangaluru, Hubballi-Dharwad-Belagavi, Tumakuru, Kalaburagi and Shivamogga are being developed to take Karnataka's digital and knowledge economy beyond Bengaluru.

If a young person can find a technology job in Mysuru, there is less need for him/her to move to Bengaluru. If a Global Capability Centre comes up in Mangaluru, employment can remain within coastal Karnataka. If advanced manufacturing grows across Hubballi-Dharwad-Belagavi, young people from North Karnataka can find opportunities closer home.

The process is already visible. In June 2026, 55 industrial projects worth ₹7,506 crore were



D.K. Shivakumar

The Chief Minister of Karnataka

The State's next chapter cannot depend on one city; it must be powered by many economic engines beyond Bengaluru

approved, with the potential to create more than 28,000 jobs. Of these, 41 are planned outside Bengaluru Urban and Bengaluru Rural districts. In August 2026, another 83 projects worth around ₹6,253 crore were approved, of which 69 are planned outside Bengaluru, with the potential to create more than 30,000 jobs.

These are approved projects and projected employment figures, not completed investments. But they demonstrate that investment is increasingly being directed beyond Bengaluru. The Local Economy Accelerator Programme (LEAP) has been allocated ₹1,000 crore over five years to promote startups, entrepreneurship and emerging technology clusters beyond Bengaluru, with a target of creating five lakh employment opportunities.

Building around each region's strengths

Under the 2026-27 Budget, LEAP Labs are proposed in Hubballi, Kalaburagi, Hoskote and Mysuru, along with a K-Combinator accelerator and stronger industry-academia linkages. Crucially, the aim is not to copy Bengaluru elsewhere. It is to build ecosystems around the distinct strengths of each region.

For instance, coastal Karnataka has strong foundations in ports, maritime connectivity, education, health care, banking, fisheries and tourism, along with a growing knowledge economy. The next step is to connect these strengths with technology and the digital economy. Similarly, Mysuru already has strong foundations in education, tourism and technology. The government has set the goal of developing it as Karnataka's second IT city under the 2026-27 Budget. Mysuru should not be Bengaluru's replacement; it should become another major technology and knowledge-economy engine for Karnataka.

The Hubballi-Dharwad-Belagavi cluster has strong foundations in engineering, manufacturing, education and entrepreneurship. It is being developed as an emerging cluster for Artificial Intelligence (AI), machine learning, Internet of Things and advanced manufacturing. Available KDEM data indicate more than 400

startups and over 80 funded startups in the cluster, with more than 4,500 jobs added. The next step is to build on this foundation through AI, data science, drones, electric vehicles (EV), Software as a Service (SaaS), agritech and advanced manufacturing. Tumakuru and Doddaballapura have been identified as an industrial node with the potential to attract around ₹7,000 crore in investment and create more than 88,000 jobs.

So, clearly, 'Beyond Bengaluru' does not mean giving every district the same development model. It means identifying each region's strengths and building the right economic ecosystem around them.

The 'Beyond Bengaluru' model

The goal is also not simply to build IT parks or factories. Education, skills, health care, connectivity, housing and employment must grow together. When industries come, local Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSME) must benefit. When jobs are created, local youth must have the necessary skills. As cities expand, workers need quality housing, while their families need schools and health care. Tourism must create income for local communities.

That is why the 'Live Near Work' approach, with quality housing close to industrial areas, is important. Industry and human development are two parts of the same economic system. Agriculture must also be part of this transformation. Drones, satellite imagery, digital technology and AI can support crop surveys, crop-health assessment, pest and disease monitoring and real-time agricultural intelligence. Value addition, food processing and stronger supply chains can further strengthen rural economies.

This 'Beyond Bengaluru' model is one that spreads Bengaluru's success across Karnataka. Bengaluru should remain the crown of Karnataka. But the brilliance of that crown must be visible in every district. It means taking the success of Bengaluru and creating new centres of success across the State – a Karnataka powered by many economic engines.

Turning economic cooperation into shared prosperity

At a time when the international landscape is becoming more complex and uncertain, the case for meaningful international cooperation has rarely been stronger. Its value must increasingly be measured by its ability to deliver stability, resilience and shared prosperity.

For the United Arab Emirates (UAE), this is central to how it approaches BRICS. Since becoming a full member in January 2024, its engagement has been guided by a straightforward principle: economic cooperation should create tangible opportunities for countries, businesses and people.

A diversity that creates opportunities

The strength of BRICS lies partly in its diversity. Its members bring different economic structures, resources, capabilities and development experiences – from major producers and consumers to sources of capital, investment destinations, energy exporters and manufacturing centres.

These differences create opportunities for complementarity – connecting markets, capital, capabilities and ideas in ways that can benefit its members, and by extension the Global South.

The UAE's participation in BRICS is part of its broader commitment to multilateralism, constructive dialogue and diversified international partnerships. It seeks to build bridges between economies and regions. It supports an open international system that advances peace, stability, sustainable development and shared prosperity.

For the UAE, BRICS' ultimate value lies in implementation. Dialogue should translate into easier trade, stronger investment flows, more resilient supply chains, better connectivity and greater opportunities for businesses.

India's 2026 BRICS Chairship, centered on resilience, innovation, cooperation and sustainability, provides a timely framework for this agenda. At a time when trade restrictions, supply-chain disruptions and uncertainty are increasing costs for businesses and consumers, the response should not be to retreat from global economic integration, but to make it more resilient and inclusive.

BRICS stands out when cooperation can produce tangible benefits: through strengthening



Saeed bin Mubarak Al Hajeri

Minister of State at the United Arab Emirates Ministry of Foreign Affairs

The United Arab Emirates promotes open, resilient economic cooperation through its engagement with BRICS

the multilateral trading system, facilitating trade and investment, improving connectivity, supporting resilient global value chains, and promoting sustainable development.

Development finance is also part of this equation. The New Development Bank (NDB) has approved more than \$40 billion in financing since its establishment, supporting infrastructure and sustainable development across its member countries. The UAE's active engagement with the NDB long before joining BRICS reflects its wider commitment to mobilising capital towards productive investment and long-term growth.

The UAE's own economic partnership with India demonstrates what practical connectivity can achieve.

On UAE-India ties, the UAE's advantages

The UAE-India Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement has helped create a more enabling environment for trade and investment between two highly complementary economies. In 2025, non-oil bilateral trade grew by 17% to exceed \$76 billion and the UAE and India have set the ambition of increasing bilateral trade to \$200 billion by 2032.

But the strength of the UAE-India relationship extends beyond trade. It is reinforced by investment, innovation, education, tourism and long-standing connections between their businesses, institutions and people.

This experience points to a broader lesson for BRICS: the strongest economic partnerships are built not only through agreements between governments, but through lasting connections across societies – creating the trust, opportunity, and resilience that allow commercial ties to deepen over time.

Economic connectivity is strengthened when businesses, entrepreneurs, investors, and institutions develop greater familiarity with one another. It is reinforced through education, research, tourism, cultural exchange and engagement of younger generations, which help build the trust and networks on which longer-term economic relationships grow.

The opportunity for BRICS is therefore to deepen the quality of connectivity among its members – connecting not only economies but also institutions, ideas and people.

The UAE is particularly well positioned to contribute because connectivity lies at the heart of its own economic model.

Non-oil sectors accounted for almost 79% of GDP in 2025, supported by world-class infrastructure, trusted financial institutions, advanced logistics and energy capabilities, and an open investment environment that enables businesses to scale-upwards and outwards.

The UAE's ports, airports and logistics networks connect markets across Asia, Africa, Europe and beyond. Its financial centres connect international capital with opportunities across the region, while, its universities, research institutions and innovation ecosystem connect talent, knowledge and ideas.

With sovereign wealth assets exceeding \$2.9 trillion, and 38 concluded Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreements, the UAE has built the capacity to connect capital, markets and economies at scale.

For the UAE, connectivity is not simply about moving goods from one market to another. It is about creating the conditions in which capital, knowledge, technology, talent and people can interact and create new opportunities.

The UAE's approach is not to build economic cooperation around division, but around connectivity.

The path under India's leadership

As India leads BRICS through 2026, there is an opportunity to move further toward delivery: building resilience without closing markets, supporting innovation while widening opportunity, and strengthening connections among the businesses, institutions and people of the UAE and India. The UAE also looks ahead with confidence to China's BRICS Chairship in 2027, where it hopes to build on the momentum of India's leadership and carry forward the same energy of openness, connectivity and practical cooperation.

Ultimately, the success of BRICS cooperation will be measured by the opportunities it creates. That is the approach that the UAE brings to BRICS. As India hosts the 2026 Summit (September 12-13), the UAE stands ready to continue the work that translates cooperation into ways that support shared prosperity.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Dhaka and Sheikh Hasina

Bangladesh's demand for Sheikh Hasina's extradition has placed India in a delicate diplomatic position. Dhaka wants Ms. Hasina to return to face charges related to the student uprising, while India must balance its earlier close ties with the deposed leader against its relations with the present Bangladeshi government. The best option is neither immediate extradition nor outright refusal, but a strictly legal and diplomatic approach. India should examine the request under the extradition treaty and

seek assurances of a fair trial, due process and protection from political persecution, while maintaining dialogue with Dhaka. This would protect India's credibility, avoid confrontation and preserve long-term bilateral relations.

R.S. Narula, Patiala, Punjab

BRICS is a multilateral organisation and it would be beneficial for Bangladesh to participate in the summit at the highest level. However, linking its participation to Sheikh Hasina's extradition may

not be a smart foreign policy approach. As neighbours linked by civilisational ties and practical considerations, such as a shared border and water-sharing arrangements, it would be in the national interests of both India and Bangladesh to set aside sensitive issues such as Ms. Hasina's extradition and move forward with their bilateral and multilateral relations.

Belated search for peace

There is talk of India exploring ways to

contribute to ending the ongoing Russia-Ukraine conflict. One cannot help but wonder why it has taken so long. The war has caused an enormous loss of life, destruction and suffering. What is particularly distressing for Indians is the reported recruitment of Indian nationals who went to Russia in search of employment but were subsequently drawn into military service and sent to the war front. If Indians were deceived or coerced into fighting a foreign war, should not the Indian government have taken a

much stronger position and demanded accountability? For over a decade, India has repeatedly projected itself as a country capable of speaking to both sides. Yet, when there are signals that India is seeking ideas that could contribute to ending the conflict, the initiative sounds rather belated.

Tharcus S. Fernando, Chennai

Eiffel Tower 'incident'

The revolutionaries of 1789 articulated their demands around three core principles: liberty, equality and fraternity. Yet, we are witnessing a troubling

departure from these very ideals in the controversy surrounding the recent protest at the Eiffel Tower – and the allegation of asking women staff to make themselves invisible. The incident calls for deeper introspection. Even as societies aspire to progress and global leadership, institutional practices can continue to perpetuate attitudes that overlook systemic gender discrimination.

Rishika Singh,

Dhanbad, Jharkhand

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

India has to act on its ‘sugar’ problem

This week, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI), prodded by the Supreme Court, proposed a simple but overdue idea. Packaged foods high in fat, salt, or sugar should carry a bold red warning on the front of the pack, not buried in fine print on the back. Someone picking up instant noodles, a breakfast cereal, or a “health drink” will finally be told, at a glance, that it is not as wholesome as its advertising claims. This is a welcome step. It is also, on its own, nowhere near enough.

The number of children presenting with morbid obesity and diabetes has climbed sharply within just a few years. The World Obesity Atlas 2026 bears this out – 41 million Indian children and adolescents aged 5 to 19 are now overweight or obese. This is not just because children are eating more; it is about what they are being sold. Breakfast cereals, sweetened yoghurts, and “health drinks” are marketed to parents as filling gaps in a child’s diet, emphasising “energy” and vitamins while saying little about the sugar content inside. In 2024, a leading multinational was found adding sugar to infant food sold in India and other lower income countries; sugar was left out of the same product in Europe. When a health drink, popular in Indian homes, turned out to be nothing more than flavoured sugar syrup, it took a social media storm, and not a regulator, to force the company to prescribe a 15% cut in its added sugar.

The problem is worse around schools and colleges, where studies show that the cheapest, most easily



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When the U.K. introduced its soft drinks industry levy, sugar consumption fell. Manufacturers reformulated their drinks to slip below the tax threshold rather than raise prices

available snacks are also the least healthy. A popular “energy drink” among teenagers, priced at just ₹20, packs close to 17 grams of sugar, caffeine, and artificial colour into a single bottle. Its label says it is not meant for children, yet nothing stops a child from buying it. This is the market pricing unhealthy calories to fit within the range of a child’s pocket money.

Need for enforcement None of this is a secret. What has been missing is enforcement. The FSSAI and the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) have long recommended what schools should not sell, but optional rules get treated as optional, and canteens stock whatever sells cheapest. A red warning label only works if it is actually enforced.

Moreover, the new rule stops at the edge of organised retail. Most of India’s sugar, salt, and trans fat is eaten unbranded, from street stalls, dhabas, and sweet shops that make up the unorganised sector, none of which is required to declare anything. A red label on a biscuit packet does nothing about the jalebi sold loose beside it. Regulation that reaches only packaged food leaves the unregulated half of the plate untouched.

Then there is the conversation India keeps avoiding – a tax on sugar. When the U.K. introduced its soft drinks industry levy, sugar consumption among both children and adults fell. Manufacturers reformulated their drinks to slip below the tax threshold rather than raise prices. A well-designed sugar tax does not just discourage people from buying a product, it pushes the industry to make the

product itself less harmful.

India already taxes sugary drinks heavily; just not usefully. Since September 2025, aerated and sweetened beverages, sugar free versions included, were folded into one 40% GST slab – so a ‘normal’ cola and its zero-sugar counterpart pay the same tax, leaving manufacturers with no reason to cut sugar. The U.K.’s levy worked differently, taxing drinks in tiers by sugar content, so that companies could lower their bill by reformulating the product. India could tax products in the same way so that manufacturers have a reason to cut sugar.

The standard objection – that such a tax would hit the poor the hardest – is not wrong, but it is only half the argument. Unregulated, cheap sugar already extracts a heavy price from the poor, who bear the brunt of the diabetes, hypertension and childhood obesity epidemic that sugar heavy diets drive, with the least means to treat it. Doing nothing is not neutral; it is a slower, costlier tax, paid in ill health rather than rupees at the till. The answer is to design the tax calibrated to sugar content so that it nudges reformulation, with part of the revenue set aside to make healthy food cheaper.

The FSSAI’s proposed red label is a genuine, if belated, first step. What India needs now is the resolve to finish what it has started – mandatory food standards; limits on how unhealthy food is marketed to children; rules that reach the unorganised sector; and an honest debate on taxing sugar in a way that protects families with the least room to absorb either cost, the tax, or the disease.

The many ways to destroy a book

Last month, a group of citizens in Ahmedabad gathered to read books by Pakistani education activist Malala Yousafzai and Holocaust survivor Anne Frank. This was their way of protesting against the Bajrang Dal and Vishwa Hindu Parishad for forcing a private school to drop books by Yousafzai and Frank from its compulsory reading list. Soon, members of the Bajrang Dal arrived at the scene, beat up the group, and tore up the books.

The targeting of books is as old as the book itself. Books have been censored, banned, torn, burnt, and pulverised to suppress opposing views, enforce state ideologies, silence uncomfortable truths, or for being deemed heretical.

Earlier this month, too, the destruction of books was in the news – but for a very different reason. Various reports in international media said that rare-book sellers were surprised to see a sudden increase in sales. However, the books were not being bought by specialised dealers, collectors, or connoisseurs; they were being purchased by buyers with strange names – Red Sparrow Project, Blue Finch Project, and Green Parrot Project – to train Large Language Models (LLMs) such as ChatGPT. These valuable editions ended up in warehouses, where their spines were sliced, their pages scanned, and the books pulped, so that AI companies would not have to deal with the headache of copyright and e-books.

Why are these two different groups targeting books? The Bajrang Dal said it disapproved of Yousafzai’s perceived views on India and Kashmir. Here, there is a



Radhika Santhanam

clear ideological opposition to Yousafzai’s ideas. The organisation carried out the deliberate act of thrashing people and tearing up books to send a clear warning: do not read this book; and if you do, face our wrath.

In the AI case, there is no such ideological opposition. The book is seen by companies as a mere object that contains ideas. And those ideas are not dangerous; on the contrary, they are important because they can be mined for profit. The more the knowledge fed into LLMs, the greater their capacity to respond, and the more dependent we become on them. What makes this even more worrying is that not all such extraction and destruction is seen as damaging to our cultural spaces or as insults to creators. Not too long ago, a U.S. court ruled that Anthropic’s use of copyrighted books to train its AI was not, in itself, copyright infringement. “One replaced the other,” one of the judges wrote. “There is no evidence that the new, digital copy was shown, shared, or sold outside the company.”

This means that within the framework of our current understanding of “fair use”, a company can buy books written by human beings, copy their contents into a machine, and then destroy the books without even having to compensate the writers. Surely, we need to ask ourselves: have we understood the words “fair” and “use” too narrowly?

Why books matter This practice unsurprisingly sparked widespread anger, which brings us to a more fundamental question: what does the physical book mean to us?

When a book is given to a

child, it can become a precious possession, a way to travel into different worlds of imagination. A book given as a gift by a friend can become a warm memory. A book borrowed from a library for research can be carried around as a vessel of knowledge. A book purchased from a rare-books shop can be as precious as silver, containing layers of history. Books, therefore, have always been more than paper and ink and a spine. They are, of course, textual instruments, but they are also cultural objects – repositories of our thoughts, wanderings, dealings, and feelings. If ideas are what makes us human, books, then, are a physical manifestation of those ideas, which we choose to preserve and pass on.

In *Burning the Books*, Richard Ovenden writes about how, when the National and University Library of Bosnia and Herzegovina came under artillery fire from the Serbian military in 1992, librarians formed a human chain to protect books. In Nazi Germany, a group of Jewish intellectuals, known as the ‘Paper Brigade’, risked execution by hiding books inside their clothing. In the Soviet Union, Samizdat involved clandestinely copying and circulating censored texts, while the modern copyleft movement allows creators to choose to reproduce and share their work freely.

Today, in a world where books are seen either as dangerous or as useful raw material – rather than as things to be read – the ways in which we defend books may have to keep evolving.

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Trade between BRICS countries shows marked increase

The rise in intra-BRICS trade strengthens the case for a cross-border payments system

DATA POINT

Nitika Francis
Gandla Sneha

Reducing global dependence on the U.S. dollar is expected to be a key part of the discussions in the 18th BRICS Summit, chaired by India, happening in New Delhi on September 12 and 13, 2026. Finance ministries’ and central bank governors from BRICS countries met in August to discuss the facilitation of cross-border payments and strengthening of national currencies.

The BRICS bloc with its 10 member countries – Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, Egypt, Ethiopia, Indonesia, Iran, and the UAE – has grown in strength in its objective of advancing trade and diplomatic relations within the Global South, which makes cross-border payments desirable.

Currently, making payments across countries requires a string of transactions via correspondent banks, which hold accounts with each other. When two countries do not have such correspondent banks, they route their payments through international banks, converting the currency of the sender country to a dominant currency such as dollars, and then converting the dollars to the currency of the receiving country. This process, besides being slow at times, comes with the cost of foreign exchange margins and the fee charged by the intermediaries. Seeing that the BRICS comprises many developing economies, this can be among the many impediments to trade opportunities.

Trade data shows that merchandise exports by BRICS countries made up about one-fourth of all global exports in 2024 (**Chart 1**). The BRICS countries have all drastically increased their exports over the years, with China touching \$500 billion in 2024. Other members such as Brazil, India, Indonesia, Russia, and the UAE also re-

corded large figures between \$80 and \$180 billion. In addition to this, their trade amongst each other has also increased. **Chart 2** shows that as of 2024, all members of BRICS, except China, received more than 30% of imports from other members.

Iran depends on BRICS for more than 65% of its imports, and Ethiopia nearly 45%. Intra-BRICS import dependency could be on the rise due to the heterogeneity of goods available among its members, as noted in a report by the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development.

Concurrently, export dependency within the bloc has also risen. In the last decade, five members (Russia, China, the UAE, Brazil, and Indonesia) have doubled and even quadrupled their exports to members of the bloc. However, China has consistently shown the lowest dependency on intra-BRICS exports due to its diversified export market (**Chart 3**).

Russia saw a rapid increase in its export dependency between 2020 and 2023, in the middle of its invasion of Ukraine, during which countries such as India imported its fuel. The country saw a decline in export dependence in 2024.

It was under Russia’s chairmanship in 2024 that the BRICS argued against the dominance of the U.S. dollar. Russia was hit directly by the dollar monopoly in 2022; due to sanctions from the U.S., Russian banks were cut off from the Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Technologies (SWIFT) which enables institutions to settle amounts. Hence, international transactions proved difficult for the Russia.

While the U.S. is the largest economy in the world, the BRICS bloc does not fall far behind, as China, India, and Russia are in the top 10 in terms of Gross Domestic Product (current prices) (**Table 1**). Whether this collective economic strength can challenge the dominance of the dollar is to be seen in the coming days.

Dollar detour

The data for the charts were sourced from report by the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development titled “Two Decades of Intra-BRICS Trade: Trends, Patterns and Policies” and the International Monetary Fund (IMF)



CHART 1: In 2025, exports from BRICS countries made up about 25% of global merchandise exports. BRICS countries include Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, Egypt, Ethiopia, Indonesia, Iran, and the UAE. Values in \$ trillion

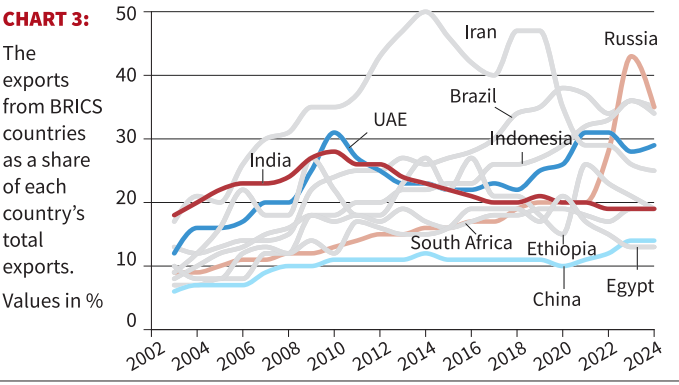
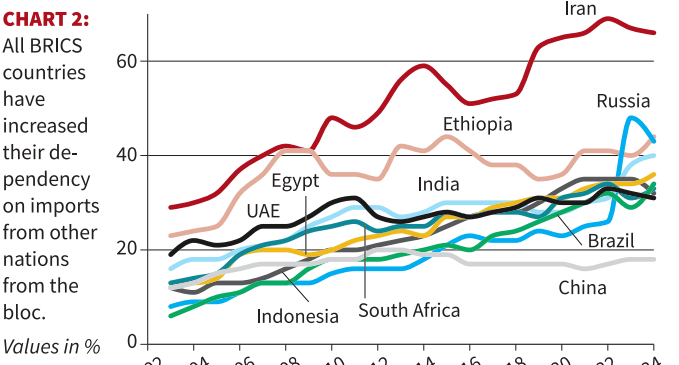
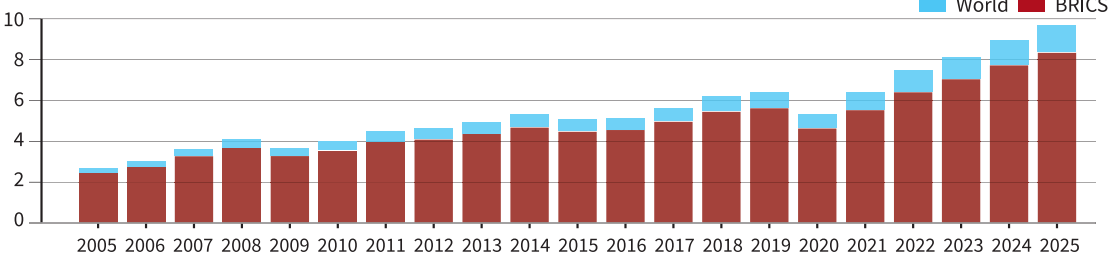


TABLE 1: Country-wise size and ranking of Gross Domestic Product of 2025 (current prices). Values are estimated by IMF

Country	GDP, current prices (billions of \$)	Rank
China	19,626.247	2
India	3,916.312	7
Russian Federation	2,587.938	9
Brazil	2,279.918	12
Indonesia	1,445.642	18
United Arab Emirates	571.643	32
South Africa	427.141	43
Iran	371.196	46
Egypt	364.64	47
Ethiopia	109.109	74

“Collectively, the 10 member countries account for 27 per cent of world output, 24 per cent of merchandise exports, and 22 per cent of FDI inflow by 2024” - Two Decades of Intra-BRICS Trade: Trends, Patterns and Policies report

Gandla Sneha is interning with The Hindu

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 10, 1976

Mao Tse-tung dead

Peking, September 9: Mao Tse-tung, the 82-year-old father of Communist China, died to-day at 10 minutes past midnight. Radio Peking broadcast the news to the 750 million Chinese saying: “Mao Tse-tung passed away at 00-10 hours on Sept. 9 because of the worsening of his illness and despite all treatment, although meticulous medical care was given to him in every way after he fell ill.”

Funeral music followed, and immediately thousands of people, wearing black armbands, began to gather in the vast Tien An Men Square (Square of Heavenly Peace) in the heart of Peking. In factories, shops and apartment blocks people gathered around loudspeakers and radio sets. Their faces turned grim and sorrowful at the news of the death of the man who had commanded their reverence and awe. Chairman Mao would have been 83 on December 26. He had been suffering from Parkinson’s disease.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 10, 1926

The Nizam’s protest

The following is from ‘The Daily Herald’ – It is reported from Bombay, says the Indian News Service, that His Exalted Highness, the Nizam of Hyderabad has sent a very strongly worded protest to the Viceroy, urging that in future the relations of the Nizam should be with the Viceroy as representative of the King and not with the Government of India. The Nizam’s contention is that the he had never entered into treaty negotiations with the Indian Government, but only with the British Government.

The Government of India is becoming gradually responsible to the people of India and the Nizam contends, it would be beneath his dignity to owe allegiance to a Government controlled by the people.

The Nizam is strongly supported in this protest by other Indian princes, who look with unconcealed perturbation on the growing encroachment on their “fundamental rights guaranteed by treaties”. The very idea of the Indian people taking to task the old-time rulers is galling to the Maharajahs and Nawabs.

It is a problem which is pressing more and more closely on the Government of India. That Government, however, is anxious, if possible, to postpone the decisive struggle with the old-time rulers – its hands being too full with the problems of the existing situation.

THE HINDU

500 in ₹ crore. The Chhattisgarh Cabinet on Wednesday approved a ₹500 crore startup and skills mission aimed at creating new opportunities for employment, skill development, entrepreneurship and innovation for the youth of the State, officials said. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

OpenAI later said 10,000 AI agents had solved the problem in an 88-hour effort, while Buckmaster alleged that OpenAI made questionable proposals over publication and authorship

INBRIEF



India's Lohum ships first lithium ore from Zimbabwe

India's Lohum said on Wednesday it had dispatched its first shipment of lithium ore from Zimbabwe, marking the start of its mining operations in the southern African country and making it the first domestic company to produce lithium from overseas assets. The Indian producer of sustainable critical minerals has secured rights to 10 lithium mining blocks in Zimbabwe's Matabelel and South Province covering about 1,100 hectares, with estimated deposits of 30 million-40 million tonnes of ore. The assets are expected to support production of around 3,00,000 metric tonnes of lithium carbonate equivalent and carry an estimated value of about \$7 billion at current prices. REUTERS

IGL to deny CNG to vehicles without hydro-test certificates

Retail outlets of Indraprastha Gas Ltd (IGL) will not dispense compressed natural gas (CNG) to vehicles without a valid hydro-test certificate, the company said on Tuesday. Under government regulations, every CNG cylinder must undergo hydrotesting once every three years at a testing centre approved by the Petroleum and Explosives Safety Organisation (PESO). The mandatory test is conducted to check cylinders for leaks, structural defects, durability and corrosion. "To support compliance with the safety requirements, IGL is conducting a special safety drive across all its CNG stations. Before refuelling, station personnel are verifying the hydro-test validity and checking the certificate," the company said.

Eleven insurers begin Ind AS transition from FY27

As many as 11 insurance companies have begun the transition to Indian Accounting Standards (Ind AS) from FY27, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) said on Wednesday. Among these, SBI General Insurance, Niva Bupa Health Insurance and Star Health and Allied Insurance have submitted their financial numbers for Q1 FY27 under Ind AS. Other insurers that have started the transition include life insurers Acko and Tata AIA, general insurers Acko, Kiwi and ECGC; health insurers Aditya Birla and Galaxy; and foreign insurance branch XL Insurance Company SE-India Reinsurance Branch (Axa XL).

Bandhan Bank turning full-fledged, universal: MD

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Having started from a microfinance background, Bandhan Bank is now getting into credit cards and wealth management to become a full-fledged universal bank, its MD & CEO said in an interaction.

"We are now moving towards a real universal bank. We have been perceived as a microfin bank, but now we are gradually evolving from a microfin to a universal bank. And so that's why both our liabilities and assets are getting distributed," said Partha Pratim Sengupta, MD & CEO, Bandhan Bank.

"So, on the liability front we are now catering to the poor strata of the economy, the microfin borrowers, and on the other side, the affluent borrowers also," Mr. Sengupta said.

"Similarly, on the asset side, we have made the book much, much more secular. So, we have today one third of our book in microfinance, one third in housing and retail, and one third in wholesale banking, and that we will continue to do. So the assets, risks, everything, it gets distributed," he said. The bank has launched a range of credit cards for customers.

Double deflation debate over GDP methodology is no 'great battle'

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

There is no winner in the ongoing "battle" of views on the use of double deflation in India's new GDP series, Ashok Kumar Lahiri, Vice Chairman of Niti Aayog, the government's economic think tank, said on Tuesday, arguing that the methodology is neither impractical nor particularly difficult to implement.

Deflating the price effects at the producer and consumer expenditure of GDP (gross domestic product) "is not a great battle," he said on the sidelines of a fintech event in Mumbai.

"For double deflation, all that you need to do is separate the inputs from the outputs. That's not a great battle. So I don't think double deflation methodologically is an impossibility. Can it be improved? Of course, everything can be improved. It's a good time to start," Mr. Lahiri said.

Mr. Lahiri also questioned why concerns over methodology were being raised now, noting that GDP growth rates in the new series, based on 2023-24 prices, are lower than those under the earlier series with 2011-12 as the base year.

U.S. labour dept. puts Cognizant's green card filings on hold

Action amid alleged fraud probe puts new PERM filings on hold; experts say tech firms could face tough scrutiny of visa sponsorship, recruitment

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

The U.S. Department of Labour has suspended Cognizant Technology Solutions' (CTS) filings under the Permanent Labour Certification (PERM) programme, a key step for employers seeking employment-based green cards for foreign workers, amid an investigation into alleged fraud. "Cognizant's PERM filings are suspended," U.S. Labour Department Inspector General Anthony D'Esposito announced on X, adding that the department was working with the White House Task Force to eliminate fraud.

"Threats to American workers will not be tolerated," he added.

The department has not disclosed the specific allegations against Cognizant, the number of filings affected or how long the suspension will remain in force. The material released by the inspector general also does not identify any criminal charges against Cognizant.

PERM is the labour-certification stage of the employment-based permanent residency process. Under the programme, the Labour Department must



Long-term hazard: A prolonged suspension could create a talent-retention risk for Cognizant, it is said. REUTERS

certify that qualified U.S. workers are not available for a position and that hiring a foreign worker will not adversely affect the wages and working conditions of similarly employed American workers.

EITREND CEO Pareekh Jain said a prolonged suspension could create a talent-retention risk for Cognizant if it affects employees already in the green-card queue.

He said employees could consider moving to other companies if their permanent-residency process remains stalled, making it a potential medium-term issue for Cognizant.

Broader impact

Mr. Jain said the impact could be broader if similar action is taken against other technology companies, potentially pushing the industry towards more local

hiring. He also said the significance of the move was that immigration scrutiny could now extend beyond H-1B hiring to the H-1B-to-green-card pathway. He also questioned why Cognizant was the first pick, noting that although it was founded in Chennai, it is a U.S.-headquartered and Nasdaq-listed company.

He said this suggested the move is intended to be less about an India-U.S. issue and more about sending a signal to the wider IT industry, although the U.S. government has not stated this as its rationale.

In his LinkedIn post, Piyal Gupta, CEO of Kneuralabs and a former Accenture and Cognizant executive, said the suspension was significant for the global IT industry because PERM is a critical step in the employment-based green-card process.

AAHL inks pact to raise \$1 billion from investors for 5.54% stake

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Adani Airport Holdings Limited (AAHL), a subsidiary of Adani Enterprises Limited (AEL) and one of India's largest private airport operators, has entered into binding agreements to raise ₹9,825 crore (\$1 billion) of primary equity capital from a consortium of investors comprising Alpha Wave Global, Premji Invest, Temasek and Black-Rock managed funds.

The transaction values AAHL at a pre-money equity valuation of \$18 billion and represents one of the largest primary equity investments from financial institutions in India's airport infrastructure sector.

AAHL and the investors have entered into a Share Subscription Agreement and a Shareholders' Agreement pursuant to which the investors will subscribe to new equity shares of AAHL in three tranches, with the final tranche expected to be completed by July 2027.

Upon completion of all three tranches, the investors will collectively hold approximately 5.54% in AAHL.

The proceeds will support expansion and modernisation of airport infrastructure across AAHL's portfolio and accelerate development of integrated Adani Airport City ecosystems around its airports.

Global oil prices surge over \$100 a barrel as tensions in West Asia escalate

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Benchmark Brent Crude futures (November) spiralled to a more than three-and-half month high at \$101.55 for every barrel Tuesday as renewed tensions in West Asia fuelled further with Iran and United States resorting to a violent quid pro quo exchange on each other's ships.

At the time of writing late evening Wednesday, benchmark Brent Crude futures were trading 3.6% higher over its previous close at \$101.43 for every barrel. West Texas Intermediate futures had also soared 3.6% higher over its previous close at \$96.44 for every barrel.

Further, according to government data, India's crude oil basket was averaging \$108.91 per barrel on September 8.

Reflecting on the current oil price trends, Prashant Vashisht, senior vice president and co-group head, corporate sector ratings, at ratings agency ICRA observed that at the current benchmark prices until September in the ongoing month, petrol and diesel were incurring under-recoveries of ₹5 per litre and ₹23 per litre and under recoveries on domestic LPG are at ₹200/cylinder.

"If the current geopoliti-



India's crude oil basket was averaging \$108.91 per barrel on September 8. REUTERS

cal situation persists, crude oil prices could rise further given that several countries including China were tapping their strategic reserves for a significant proportion of their consumption and their return to the market could increase demand amid restricted supplies," he observed.

Although, according to shipping data from Vortexa and Kpler, drone and missile attacks in Saudi Arabia's Jazan refinery have offered prospects for Indian refiners to export and meet the emerging demand for diesel in Europe. Exports have surged to about 120,000 barrels per day in August, shipping data indicates.

India, the world's third-largest oil importing country, is particularly exposed to swings in international crude prices. For now, retail petrol and diesel prices remain on freeze for over three months.

Kenya to set up high-level committee to resolve issues with Tata Chemicals unit

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Kenya's Ministry of Mining, Blue Economy, and Maritime Affairs has announced the establishment of a high-level technical committee to ad-

dress compliance concerns raised by Tata Chemicals Magadi Ltd. in July 2026 and to resolve outstanding matters.

"Following the suspension of operations at Tata Chemicals Magadi Limited, today at my office, I led a

fruitful engagement with the Company's executives regarding the compliance concerns we raised as a Ministry," Hassan Ali Joho, EGH Cabinet Secretary, Ministry of Mining, Blue Economy and Maritime Affairs said in a letter.

The committee will undertake a detailed technical review of the outstanding and unresolved compliance matters, prepare and submit a report to my office for consideration and further direction, he stated.

PM-KUSUM 2.0 likely to be announced soon: Pralhad

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

The second phase of the Centre's flagship PM-KUSUM scheme is likely to be announced shortly, Union Minister for New and Renewable Energy Pralhad Joshi said on the sidelines of the seventh Agrivoltaics World Conference 2026.

"The process is on for PM-KUSUM 2.0, that is, Phase-II, and I am quite confident very shortly the honourable Prime Minister [will make the announcement]," Mr. Joshi told reporters.

Addressing the conference, the Minister said the next phase of the scheme would include a dedicated component for agrivoltaics, which combines agricultural activity with solar power generation.

Mr. Joshi said the government's broader focus would remain on supporting small and marginal farmers, farmer producer organisations (FPOs), cooperatives and panchayats as the country expands the use of renewable energy in agriculture.

He also called on industry stakeholders and researchers to deepen studies on agrivoltaic applications.

Women's representation in senior corporate roles falls; Avtar flags US DEI pullback

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

Women's representation in senior corporate positions in India has declined, with their share of Corporate Executive roles at companies featured in the Avtar-Seramount Best Companies for Women in India study falling to 16.7% in 2026 from 20% a year earlier.

Overall, women's representation across the companies surveyed fell to 34.6% from 35.7%, while their share of hiring declined to 36% from 38%, according to the 11th edition of the study.

The findings come after years of progress in women's representation at the senior-most levels. Avtar Managing Director Saundarya Rajesh attributed part of the setback to a global pullback in diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) initiatives following an executive order issued by U.S. President Donald Trump in January 2025.

"We knew that there would be challenges for women working for these companies in India," Rajesh said, referring to the impact of the U.S. policy shift on American compa-



Study finds shrinking women's representation in corporate sector. REPRESENTATIONAL PHOTO

nies and their Indian operations.

She said the retreat from DEI efforts was also affecting the broader Indian corporate market, as practices adopted by large multinational companies have historically influenced other employers.

The study covered 387 companies, of which 125 were named among the Best Companies for Women in India. Women accounted for 31.4% of the workforce at India-headquartered companies in the cohort, compared with 41.1% at US-headquartered firms and 39.2% at companies headquartered elsewhere.

At the Corporate Executive level, women's representation stood at 14.2% at India-headquartered companies, 18% at US-headquartered companies and

20% at firms headquartered in other countries.

Rajesh also pointed to the growing impact of artificial intelligence on employment, saying AI-driven "jobless growth" was affecting women more sharply. Despite the decline in representation, companies continue to report a strong business case for workplace inclusion. The proportion of Best Companies reporting an increase in operating profit as a result of inclusive practices rose to 79.2% in 2026 from 70% in 2025.

The study also highlighted challenges in retaining women after maternity leave. While 94% of women return to work immediately after maternity leave, the proportion retained after one year falls to 79%. The study did not establish whether women who leave subsequently move to other organisations or exit the workforce altogether. Health and wellbeing have also emerged as a bigger factor in women's workforce exits, overtaking childcare. About 30% of women cited health and wellbeing challenges as a reason for leaving, compared with 28% who cited childcare.

New Jawa 42 motorcycle unveiled at ₹1.8 lakh

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Jawa Yezdi Motorcycles, the brand under which Classic Legends Ltd. operates, on Wednesday unveiled Jawa 42 with over 60 enhancements at an ex-showroom price starting ₹1,79,942.

With this the company has completed the new Jawa 'All Stars' line up which comprises three modern classic motorcycles that includes the Jawa 42 FJ and Jawa 42 Bobber. The Jawa 42 started the brand's modern-day journey, with India's first modern classic range in 2018.

Anupam Thareja, co-founder, Classic Legends, said, "The most interesting communities are built by people who share a way of conducting themselves even when there is no audience." "The Jawa 42 helped launch India's modern classic category. The All Stars 42 carries that same instinct forward, not by abandoning what made the Jawa 42, but by asking what it should mean to the rider of today," he added.

The Jawa 42 is powered by a 294.72 cc single-cylinder, four-stroke, liquid-cooled DOHC engine, paired with a six-speed constant-mesh gearbox.

China extends its aluminium dominance abroad



Chinese aluminium smelter projects are also cropping up further afield. REUTERS

Reuters
LONDON

China's aluminium smelters have been running red hot this year. The Shanghai aluminium price is nudging three-month highs, raw material costs are historically low and margins are strong. Every producer is incentivised to operate their plant at maximum capacity. Indeed, national output has exceeded Beijing's 45-MMT capacity cap for the past couple of months, as smelters flex their full production potential. The mandated ceiling, however, remains in place. Chinese producers have accepted that reality and are now investing heavily in smelter projects abroad. While President Donald Trump complains the United States "desperately" needs more aluminium, the world's largest producer is consolidating its dominant position in the global supply chain.

Powering up in Indonesia

Chinese producers understand that if they want to expand, they now have to go abroad. Investment has primarily flowed into Indonesia, where new aluminium smelters can be sited in the same Chinese-built industrial parks used to process nickel. Tsingshan Group, the powerhouse behind Indonesia's nickel boom, has teamed up with Chinese aluminium producers Huaфон Group and Xinfа Group to build the new Hua Chin and Juwan smelters, respectively. Existing power and logistics infrastructure has enabled rapid construction. Hua Chin was commissioned last year with 480,000 tonnes of annual capacity. It applied in May to list its "HCAI" brand with the London Metal Exchange. Juwan shipped its first aluminium to the U.S. in March. PT Alamtri Resources Indonesia, in which China's Zhejiang Lygend Mining holds a minority interest, did the same in June.

Capacity swap

Chinese aluminium smelter projects are also cropping up further afield. In Kazakhstan, Xinfа is preparing a full-cycle industrial park with planned aluminium capacity of 2.4 million tonnes per year. Meanwhile, East Hope Group is working on a huge integrated project running from bauxite through alumina to aluminium. In Angola, a Chinese consortium led by Hebei Huatong Wire and Cables Group is backing a new smelter in the Barra do Dande free-trade zone. The first 120,000-tonne phase was constructed using equipment transferred from China, likely from an older smelter that was sacrificed for a new one and as such an international application of Beijing's capacity-swap mandate. The smelter's location on the Atlantic extends China's aluminium reach further into Western markets. The country already accounts for around 60% of global production, a ratio that has crept up to 63% due to the loss of Gulf output in the Iran war. The new generation of Chinese-backed smelters will cement that dominance as long as the West struggles to find a similarly sized response.

Reuters
LONDON

Even two wars and sky-high energy prices haven't cooled the world economy. Global growth is running hot into the second half of the year, forcing asset managers to find firebreaks while staying invested – and higher interest rates may be the only policy brake left. In the six months since the Iran war catapulted crude oil 50% higher and doubled natural gas prices, there's been a nervous wait to see how the effects would ripple across the world economy. But as the third quarter draws to a close, global activity looks to have picked up steam, if anything, driven by an AI race and corporate invest-

ment boom more than any other single factor. If inflation rates remain agitated and interest rates are pushing higher, it's because of this basic combination of strong economic growth, hot geopolitics and the supply disruptions that come with them. Just in the past week alone, some big numbers have rolled in. The unexpected surge in U.S. payrolls in August was one case in point. Euro zone and Japanese GDP for the second quarter were both revised higher, China's annual export and import growth was running at 25-30% through last month, and we've just ended a corporate earnings season with one of the fastest aggregate profit expansions on record.

India's listing bonanza: IPO window opens wide as OFS turns exit route

The unusual trend is that the initial public offering process itself has increasingly become an exit mechanism, even as questions remain over whether India has enough "I" in its IPOs – investment, innovation and infusion of fresh capital; trend now is early investors, promoters monetise ownership

EXPLAINER

Santosh V. Perumal

India Inc. is now having its heyday, with corporates celebrating a coming-out party of initial public offerings (IPOs), while promoters are cashing in through offer-for-sale (OFS) deals. The unusual trend is that the IPO process itself has increasingly become an exit mechanism, even as questions remain over whether India has enough "I" in its IPOs–investment, innovation and infusion of fresh capital.

Worldwide, OFS is strictly not a primary market route, but in India, when an unlisted firm lists on the stock exchange, an OFS can be included in the IPO prospectus, also known as a Red Herring Prospectus (RHP). Technically OFS enters through the primary market window, but it behaves like a secondary market transaction.

The OFS was nearly 1.5 times the fresh capital raised in FY26, according to NSE data. Earlier, IPO saw companies raise growth capital, but the current trend is that early investors and promoters monetise ownership. This is not necessarily negative, as a mechanism designed initially to increase public ownership has also become one of the most efficient ways for early investors, which include private equity funds, to convert paper wealth into real cash. India's public issue



Market musings: The OFS is no longer a footnote to the IPO story; but its growing dominance demands greater transparency. GETTY IMAGES/STOCKPHOTO

boom is real (as can be seen from the number of jackets of business dailies), but its character has changed.

Improving sentiment has been reflected in demand for new issues, with average IPO subscriptions more than doubling to 59.1 times in July and August from 24.5 times in April-June, while average listing gains climbed to 19.5% from 5.7%, according to NovaaOne Investment Banking.

The equity market is increasingly acting as a liquidity and exit platform for promoters and private equity investors, with capital formation becoming only one part of the story. In FY26, OFS accounted for about 59% of IPO proceeds, while PE-backed listings rose sharply, according to KPMG India data. The trend was visible earlier too. In 2025, mainboard IPOs raised about ₹1.76 lakh crore, but nearly

An Equirus Capital report said as many as 245 companies have filed their draft RHP with the market regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India

₹1 lakh crore came through OFS, implying more money went to selling shareholders than to companies. An Equirus Capital report said as many as 245 companies have filed their draft RHP with the market regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI). According to Prime Database, Indian companies had mopped up ₹5.4 lakh crore through public issues during 2021-25, of which ₹3.37 lakh crore came entirely from OFS. Major bigwigs like Life Insurance Corporation of

India, General Insurance Corporation, Coal India, Indian Railway Finance Corporation and New India Assurance had seen sizeable OFS share in their public offer. The National Stock Exchange, which recently got a nod from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) for its estimated ₹30,000 crore IPO, will be entirely through OFS, which has become the market's express exit lane for promoters and governments to dilute stakes without the complexity of a fresh issue. SBI Funds Management's more than ₹9,800 crore public offerings were entirely through OFS. Other proposed major public sector issues, like Indian Gas Exchange, Mahanadi Coalfields, and Asset Reconstruction Company India are also taking a proposed 100% OFS route. While OFS was a divestment tool for public sector

companies, it was an exit window for the private sector, and the Hyundai India listing was a clear example. The parent company did not dilute to fund Hyundai India's expansion; instead, it sold shares to Indian investors and unlocked value from its Indian subsidiary. The listing became one of India's largest IPOs, highlighting how global firms increasingly view Indian equity markets as a wealth-unlocking destination. The existing private sector public issue pipeline, comprising diverse sectors such as quick commerce, logistics, housing finance, dairy, financial services and education infrastructure, signals a sizeable proportion of OFS embedded in the issue. Companies that were on the fringes amid volatile markets are now seeking to capitalise on improving investor sentiment.

Beginning of OFS

The OFS was formally introduced in India's financial vocabulary in 2012, when SEBI put in place a dedicated exchange-based mechanism for promoters to sell shares of listed companies in a transparent manner. The aim was to make it easier for promoters of publicly traded firms to reduce their holdings and comply with the minimum public shareholding (MPS) norms. The method was largely adopted by listed companies, both state-run and private, to adhere to the MPS norms. The government used this to divest its shareholding in central public sector

enterprises (CPSEs) to achieve MPS and further dilution beyond MPS. The OFS mechanism has proved to be a big support in achieving big-ticket disinvestment in various PSUs such as ONGC, Hindustan Copper, NMDC, Oil India, NTPC, Rashtriya Chemicals and Fertilisers, NALCO and Steel Authority of India.

Global comparison

Countries such as the U.S., China, the U.K., Japan and parts of Europe have historically had large secondary equity markets, though the structures differ from India's IPO-OFS model. In the U.S. and Europe, secondary sales usually happen after a company is already public; implying that market has already achieved price discovery.

Road ahead

The future of India's capital markets cannot be built on selling yesterday's success stories alone, and a market that only converts private fortunes into public holdings creates liquidity; a market that funds new ambitions creates wealth. The OFS is no longer a footnote to the IPO story; but its growing dominance demands greater transparency. A vibrant stock market needs sellers, and a growing economy needs capital. Care should be taken to resist the temptation to count every rupee raised as capital formation; after all, financial markets, like GDP estimates, can make the movement of money appear remarkably like the creation of wealth.

Oil prices fly blind as Strait of Hormuz enigma deepens

Reuters
LONDON

How much oil is flowing through the Strait of Hormuz? Traders, energy executives and government officials are all trying to figure it out - but are reaching wildly different conclusions. It is, however, increasingly clear that this mystery has introduced a residual risk premium into crude prices that could remain deeply entrenched for months. Benchmark Brent crude neared \$100 a barrel on Tuesday, the highest level since July 23, after a fresh

wave of Iran-backed Houthi attacks on Saudi energy facilities and a warning from Tehran that it would wage "economic warfare" against the United States amid escalating tensions over Hormuz. For years, the consensus barely changed: Hormuz transited roughly 20 million barrels per day, equivalent to about one-fifth of global oil consumption. That certainty has disappeared. Today, armies of analysts, along with increasingly sophisticated AI systems, are sifting through vast streams of information to determine how

There are growing signs that Iran's grip on the strait maybe weakening

much oil is actually moving through the strait.

Challenges galore

The challenge has become exponentially harder because of the surge in "dark crossings," when tankers switch off navigation and identification systems while approaching, transiting or leaving the strait. A U.S. request for commercial satellite firms to delay imagery from the Gulf has further clouded the pic-

ture. Hence, nobody can say with confidence exactly how much oil is flowing through Hormuz on any given day. There are growing signs that Iran's grip on the strait maybe weakening. Months of tit-for-tat military exchanges have degraded Tehran's radar systems and strike capabilities near Hormuz. U.S. demining operations and a growing U.S.-protected shipping corridor along Oman's coast have allowed more vessels to enter and leave the Gulf. The multi-billion-dollar question is how many vessels? This uncertainty was

highlighted by conflicting estimates from the Trump administration. U.S. Energy Secretary Chris Wright said on September 2 that more than 17 million barrels transited the strait on August 31 under U.S. Navy supervision, a figure that would represent the highest level recorded since the war began. The claim left traders and analysts scratching their heads. More than a week later, ship-tracking firm Kpler, which uses satellite imagery, transponder signals, port logs and commercial shipping intelligence, suggested that perhaps only 6 million barrels

crossed Hormuz that day. Kpler estimates crude flows through Hormuz in August averaged only around 4.3 million barrels per day, rising to nearly 5 million bpd in the first six days of September. It also notes that transits appear to have fallen sharply in recent days. One possible explanation is that the administration is including exports from the UAE's Fujairah terminal, located outside the strait and supplied by Abu Dhabi's bypass pipeline. Moreover, a single day's observation says little about broader trends. The answer is far from obvious.

In a global economic heatwave, watch for financial wildfires

Reuters
LONDON

Even two wars and sky-high energy prices haven't cooled the world economy. Global growth is running hot into the second half of the year, forcing asset managers to find firebreaks while staying invested – and higher interest rates may be the only policy brake left. In the six months since the Iran war catapulted crude oil 50% higher and doubled natural gas prices, there's been a nervous wait to see how the effects would ripple across the world economy. But as the third quarter draws to a close, global activity looks to have picked up steam, if anything, driven by an AI race and corporate invest-

ment boom more than any other single factor. If inflation rates remain agitated and interest rates are pushing higher, it's because of this basic combination of strong economic growth, hot geopolitics and the supply disruptions that come with them. Just in the past week alone, some big numbers have rolled in. The unexpected surge in U.S. payrolls in August was one case in point. Euro zone and Japanese GDP for the second quarter were both revised higher, China's annual export and import growth was running at 25-30% through last month, and we've just ended a corporate earnings season with one of the fastest aggregate profit expansions on record.

It's no wonder then that copper prices – often seen as a barometer of global industrial activity – are rising again to record highs and have almost doubled in just five years. There are other things going on with the red metal of course, including U.S. tariff fears and various supply bottlenecks. But it still stands as a reflection of both brisk economic activity and copper demand in the blistering build out of AI data centers around the planet and higher defence spending. Measuring global business sentiment comes to the same conclusion. JP Morgan's aggregated world business surveys across manufacturing and service sectors show the global output index rose in



Money matters: People walk around the Financial District near the New York Stock Exchange. REUTERS

August for a fifth straight month to its highest in more than two years. That is consistent with a 3.1% annualised gain in global GDP, above the bank's estimate of global potential at 2.3%. Along with firming out-

put, a jump in new orders and future-output components is a positive forward-looking signal, it said. "Excluding the rebound from recessions, it (the August reading) stands in line with the peaks of mid-expansion upswings over the

past two decades." It may be a dangerous upswing, mainly because of its inflation and debt-market impact, but its strength is not in doubt. To the extent that it's driven by AI investment and defence spending, there's little sign of a slowdown next year. It's also likely the International Monetary Fund will upgrade its world growth estimate for 2026 from the 3.0% it pencilled in during July. With next year already expected to accelerate to 3.4%, its take on 2027 will be closely watched. What's more, if governments are increasingly leaning on growth to rein in rising debt-to-GDP ratios, none seem minded to tap on the fiscal brakes. That leaves central banks

once again as the only policy restraint. Normalising disruption The big investment debate of the moment hinges on how portfolio investors can keep riding this growth and how they should view the parallel rise in long-term borrowing costs to their highest in decades. For some, this cements the idea that the peculiar period in post-World War Two history was the decade after the 2008 banking crash: a cosseted era of low growth and investment, high savings and subdued inflation that was an aberration, rather than some "new normal" reinforced by ageing demographics. Deutsche Bank strategist Jim Reid insists rising

bond yields will simply re-focus investors on the coupon side of the bond proposition rather than the capital gains (or losses) part. "Bonds have become bonds again," he wrote in an opinion piece in Tuesday's Financial Times, and what we are seeing is just a "continuation of the long normalisation from the historic anomaly of the 2010s." But not everyone thinks the end of the new normal just ushers back in the old one, however much the current period of turbulent geopolitics, supply shocks, growth and investment may replicate the pre-2008 decades of the Cold War, Vietnam, Middle East oil embargoes, and financial booms and busts.

KYIV

Russian drones kill two people at Ukraine-Moldova border crossing



Russian drones hit a border crossing between Ukraine and Moldova in the southern region of Odesa, killing two people, Ukrainian and Moldovan officials said on Wednesday. Russia has struck five border crossings in recent weeks — four on the border with Moldova and one on its border with Romania, a NATO member. REUTERS

LAHORE

Pakistan orders medical colleges to expel students from Afghanistan



Pakistan has ordered medical institutions across the country to expel Afghan students and halt fresh admissions amid deteriorating ties between Islamabad and Kabul, a senior government official said on Wednesday. Afghan students already enrolled in medical programmes have also been directed to return to Afghanistan. PTI

SEOUL

North Korea builds new Yongbyon uranium enrichment facility: IAEA



North Korea has built a new uranium enrichment facility at its main Yongbyon nuclear complex, and started operating an expanded annex at its Kangson enrichment site, the nuclear watchdog IAEA said. The IAEA said the developments in North Korea's nuclear programme violated UN Security Council resolutions. REUTERS

OSLO

Norway bids final farewell to King Harald V at his funeral



Norway bade its final farewell to King Harald V in Oslo on Wednesday, with thousands lining the streets and global royals and leaders attending. A 21-gun salute opened the procession from the royal palace to Oslo Cathedral. Harald, who died aged 89 after 35 years on the throne, was remembered for his humility. AP

India, Sri Lanka sign three defence sector MoUs during Rajnath's visit

The agreements cover upgrading L70 guns for Sri Lankan Air Force and cooperation between the two countries' National Cadet Corps, National Defence Colleges; this is the first visit by an Indian Defence Minister to Sri Lanka in nearly 40 years

Meera Srinivasan
COLOMBO

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Wednesday pledged India's continued support to Sri Lanka during a meeting with Sri Lankan President Anura Kumara Dissanayake in Colombo, as the two countries inked three Memoranda of Understanding (MoU) on defence equipment and training.

Mr. Singh's visit, the first by an Indian Defence Minister to Sri Lanka in nearly 40 years, and the agreements come over a year after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Sri Lanka



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh meets Sri Lankan President Anura Kumara Dissanayake in Colombo on Wednesday. ANI

in 2025, when seven MoUs, including an overarching defence sector agreement, were signed.

The MoUs signed on Wednesday pertain to the

two countries.

During President Dissanayake's meeting with Mr. Singh, the two sides held "extensive discussions on further strengthening the existing defence, economic, maritime and regional partnerships between India and Sri Lanka", the Presidential Media Unit said in a statement.

Mutual interests

Further, Mr. Dissanayake briefed Mr. Singh on Sri Lanka's recently-launched islandwide programme to combat drug trafficking.

An official release from the Indian government said the President recalled his interactions with Mr.

Modi and reiterated that "Sri Lanka would never allow its territory to be used for any activities inimical to India's security interests".

President Dissanayake's office said he emphasised that Sri Lanka makes decisions "taking into consideration both national and regional interests", and that, as a sovereign State, Sri Lanka enters into various agreements with countries around the world while remaining mindful of regional security".

The statement from his office added that the leaders paid "special attention" to the fisheries issue in the Palk Strait.

Houthis report new Saudi strikes as conflict deepens

Agence France-Presse
SANAA

Yemen's Houthi rebels reported dozens of Saudi air strikes on Wednesday as daily attacks continued in a conflict that has reignited during the West Asia war, with hundreds of people killed in fighting near the Red Sea.

More than 40 attacks targeted several regions including the flashpoint areas of Taiz and Hodeida, the scene of fierce clashes between the Houthis and Saudi-backed government, the rebels said.

"It's a catastrophe, and the attacks are ongoing," said Mohammed Khudairi, one of nearly 20,000 who fled the fighting, according to the International Organization for Migration.

The latest salvos in Ye-



A member of Saudi-backed Yemeni forces firing a heavy machine gun during clashes in the Al-Kadha area on Tuesday. AFP

men's previously dormant conflict come a day after the Houthis set oil sites ablaze and wounded 73 in their heaviest missile and drone attacks against Saudi Arabia in years.

Saudi air strikes targeted "various areas across the governorates of Marib, Al-Jawf, Taiz and Hodeida", the rebels' *Almasirah*

TV said on Wednesday.

The Saudi civil defence later issued a warning for the southern governorate of Khamis Mushait, near Yemen, but quickly lifted it. On Tuesday, Saudi authorities vowed to respond to the Houthi attacks, saying they caused fires and temporary shutdowns at oil sites.

'Rahman wants to visit India, but agenda has to be set first'

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman is keen to visit India at the earliest but is concerned about take-away points and achievements that he will have to produce before his audience back home after a visit of this nature, said a diplomatic source of Bangladesh to *The Hindu* on Wednesday.

The official said Mr. Rahman might have skipped the multilateral BRICS summit for which he was invited by India, but that does not mean that he is trying to avoid an immediate and important neighbour like India, which has contributed and sacrificed immensely during Bangladesh's Liberation War of 1971. Mr. Rahman is aware that he may have to visit Delhi in a bilateral frame-



Tarique Rahman

work by November or early December, as the Ganga Water Treaty needs to be renewed at the earliest as it will otherwise lapse by the end of December, 2026, said the official.

Intensive meetings

The official said Mr. Rahman's visit requires setting of the agenda through intensive meetings between the officials of the two sides that are yet to begin. But Dhaka believes that apart from the Ganga Wa-

ter Treaty, which is a "rolling achievement", there is a need to look at other areas where the bilateral relationship is stuck.

"For example, in case of restarting full-scale visa facilities, lifting of trade restrictions that were imposed during the interim government in Dhaka, and usage of land ports, and restarting of full-scale commercial relationship are some of the areas where there is possibility of setting up some solid goals for achievement," said the official.

He also pointed out that one area where India could send a positive message is in the field of energy as Bangladesh is suffering from an acute crunch in energy supply. "It will be a confidence-building measure if India can assist Bangladesh in dealing with this challenge."

Shattered homes



Fiery aftermath: Smoke and flames rise from a house during an Israeli strike, carried out after the Israeli military warned residents to evacuate the area, in Khan Younis, in the southern Gaza Strip, on Wednesday. REUTERS

PM Burnham defends trade ban as Israel retaliates

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

U.K. Prime Minister Andy Burnham defended on Wednesday his government's ban on trade with illegal Israeli settlements in the West Bank after Israel retaliated against London-led Western sanctions over settler violence.

Israel ordered the closure of Britain's consulate in Jerusalem among other measures in response to the sanctions move on Tuesday by 12 countries, which condemned violence against Palestinians in the territory.

"Where people are being bullied out of their homes, intimidated, we will always stand with the underdog and take what action we can to support them," Mr. Burnham said.

AI researcher quits industry, warning that AI race is 'gambling with our lives'

Agence France-Presse
SAN FRANCISCO

An artificial intelligence researcher who left OpenAI to join Anthropic has decided to leave the industry, accusing both U.S. companies of "playing with our lives" in the race to develop AI models capable of self-improvement.

Jacob Coxon, 27, spent the past three years pre-training AI models, first at OpenAI and then, this year, at its rival Anthropic, which he considered more cautious in its approach.

Pretraining is the stage where AI models absorb

vast quantities of data.

"Neither company is acting responsibly. They are racing straight to self-improving superintelligence and gambling with our lives," Mr. Coxon said on Tuesday.

"The people building AI earnestly believe that it could kill us all by the end of the decade," he said in a post on X.

"This is not a marketing stunt," he added.

Superintelligence is the theoretical point when AI's capabilities exceed human intelligence.

Anthropic safety executive Evan Hubinger backed



Jacob Coxon

up Mr. Coxon on X.

"We really do earnestly believe AI could kill all humans!" he said, adding that he estimated that risk at more than 10% over the next decade.

Mr. Hubinger said An-

thropic is "trying its best", but does not yet have a plan to ensure an AI system that surpasses human capabilities would obey its creators. He said there was a "low" risk of that happening with current models.

Mr. Coxon's resignation comes as Anthropic prepares for its market debut, following a summer marked by unauthorised hacks carried out by AI tools during testing.

"At Anthropic, the stakes are well-understood, but they are locked in a race to get there first, despite the risk," he said.

IAEA's board reports Iran to UN Security Council for 'failure to cooperate in probe'

Associated Press
VIENNA

The UN atomic watchdog's board on Wednesday reported Iran to the UN Security Council for the first time in 20 years, citing it for failure to cooperate in a long-running investigation into uranium traces detected by inspectors at undeclared sites.

Western officials suspect that the traces could provide evidence that Iran had a secret nuclear weapons programme until 2003. Iran says that it is not pursuing nuclear weapons, and that its pro-

Iran's Ambassador to the United Nations in Vienna rejected resolution, describing it as a 'political tool'

gramme is entirely peaceful.

Reporting Iran to the Security Council opens the country to possible sanctions and asset freezes, though such punitive measures are unlikely because Iran's allies Russia and China hold veto power on the panel.

Twenty-three countries on the International Atom-

ic Energy Agency's 35-member board of governors voted for Wednesday's resolution at IAEA headquarters in Vienna.

China, Russia and Niger opposed it, while eight countries abstained and one did not vote as it was in arrears, according to diplomats who spoke on condition of anonymity to describe the outcome of the closed-door vote.

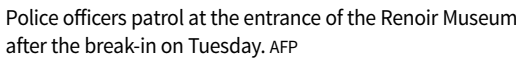
The resolution was put forward by the United States, Britain, France and Germany.

The diplomatic move has been under consideration since June 2025, when

the IAEA board found Iran officially in non-compliance with its non-proliferation obligations because of Tehran's lack of cooperation in the investigation.

Iran's Ambassador to the UN in Vienna, Reza Najafi, rejected the resolution, describing it as a "political tool" and saying that it ruined confidence in the IAEA's "independence, impartiality and credibility".

He suggested that compliance with any obligation to allow UN inspections of nuclear sites inside Iran was, in any case, impossible at the moment.

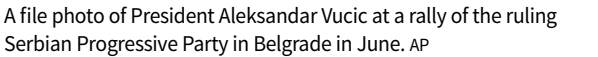


Associated Press

“Some more savvy criminal will acquire it as a get out of jail free card, sort of a bargaining chip,” said Christopher Marinello, a lawyer and founder of Art Recovery International. “So if some drug dealer ever is arrested, he can bargain with the prosecutor and say, ‘Listen, give me a lesser sentence and I’ll show you where these Renoirs are.’ And that has always worked and it will work again.”

Associated Press
SERBIA

He issued a decree dissolving the 250-member Parliament and paving the way for the vote. "We have had ... huge turbulences," Mr. Vucic said in an address. "We need election results that will clearly



The protests started after a train station tragedy on November 1, 2024, killed 16 people in northern Serbia. The protesters

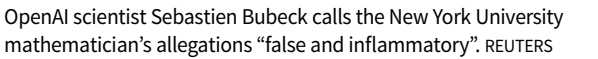
demanding accountability for the concrete canopy collapse in the city of Novi Sad and an end to the corruption they blame for substandard renovation work. Almost daily demonstrations shook Mr. Vucic

Analysts say the so-called Students' List, expected to include university professors and experts, presents a serious challenge to the ruling populists. The movement has gained huge support among the 6.5 million voters in Serbia.

Vasudevan Mukunth

In this approach, the eq-

According to a statement Mr. Buckmaster published online on September 8, he had contacted an



OpenAI researcher last week after hearing that the company was probing rumours that Anthropic had solved a major mathematical problem.

Then, on September 6, Mr. Buckmaster said he joined an urgent discussion called by OpenAI computer scientist Sebastian Bubeck and another

The revelation raised concerns as to whether OpenAI had managed to access the researchers' unpublished efforts on Codex, an OpenAI tool where Mr. Buckmaster said he

Mr. Buckmaster also alleged that Mr. Bubeck had proposed arrangements, that Mr. Buckmaster rejected, to publish OpenAI's work that would have excluded Mr. Alpoge from authorship, as the latter works for OpenAI rival Anthropic. Mr. Bubeck has since called the allegations

The Navier-Stokes problem is one of the seven Millennium Prize problems designated by the Clay Mathematics Institute, New York. The solution to each problem carries a reward of \$1 million. That said, any claim to a solution must first survive rigorous scrutiny lasting multiple years.

The Houthis of Yemen and Iraqi militias form a pincer movement to ramp up pressure on Saudi Arabia; the Tehran-backed groups jointly executed July drone attacks on Saudi oil facilities, say regional officials; armed with advanced weaponry, the Houthis threaten Riyadh's oil exports in Red Sea

Associated Press
CAIRO

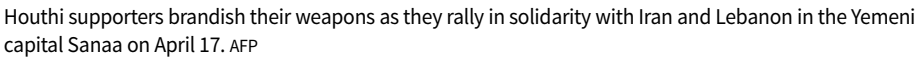
The Houthi involvement in the Iraqi drone attack was confirmed by two Sau-

Houthi-Iraqi militia ties

All the officials and the militia member spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to media. The Houthis did not respond to a request for comment.

Cooperation between the Iraqi militias and the better organised Houthis had grown throughout the war in Gaza, when they coordinated attacks on Israel, according to the Houthi and regional officials. At the height of the war, Houthi leader Abdel-Malek al-Houthi spoke of a joint operations room.

After the U.S. and Israel



“Iran has a hybrid strategy in the current war. We are not fighting on one front and we are not using one tool,” Mahdi Mohammadi, an adviser to Iran’s parliament speaker, wrote on social media in June.

“The Houthis’ growing prominence during the Gaza war opened up a new horizon in Iraq. Many groups there became eager to support the Houthis, and in return, the Houthis started sharing their military expertise with Iraqi militias,” said Ahmed Naji, senior Yemen analyst at the Crisis Group, an international think tank.

Now they are “squeezing Saudi like with pliers,” Mr. Nagi said.

A week before the drone swarm attack, the Houthis declared a blockade

Since late July, the Houthis have carried out over a dozen attacks against Saudi oil facilities and tankers in the Red Sea, according to the war monitor group ACLED.

On Tuesday, they launched a wave of attacks on oil and other facilities in southern Saudi Arabia, wounding more than 70 people, including women and children, Saudi authorities said.

The Houthi blockade has forced Saudi Arabia to adopt a “dark” transit policy that includes turning off tracking signals on oil tankers in the Red Sea, according to ACLED.

Saudi Arabia had diverted much of its oil to the Red Sea after Iran effectively closed the Strait of Hormuz. When the Houthis began attacking, the king-

dom started shipping more oil north to the Suez Canal and Egypt's SUMED pipeline, whose flows have risen from 6,50,000 barrels a day in June to over 1.9 million in August, according to global shipping monitor Kpler.

Red Sea target

Last month, the Houthis showed they can target that route as well, striking a Saudi tanker in the northern Red Sea with a missile. The tanker had reportedly travelled from the Saudi port of Yanbu to the Suez Canal, some 1,000 km from Houthi territory.

The Houthis “are willing to weather some shorter term pain for what they feel will be longer term gains” such as extending their reach along the Red Sea coast, said Adam Baron, a Yemen expert at the New America think tank in Washington.

The rebels seized Yemen's capital, Sanaa, in 2014. The following year,

To new life: A crew member helps a migrant move from an inflatable boat to a rescue boat from the migrant search and rescue ship Ocean Viking, operated by SOS Mediterranée, in the Maltese search and rescue (SAR) zone in the central Mediterranean on Tuesday. REUTERS

A IN-X

INBRIEF



Veteran Courtois to put Belgium career on hold

Goalkeeper Thibaut Courtois said in quotes published on Wednesday he had decided to put his Belgium career on standby until September 2027. The 34-year-old made the last of his 115 international appearances at this summer’s World Cup but will only return to the Red Devils set-up for Euro 2028 qualifiers next year. New boss Mark Van Bommel told Courtois beforehand he was unable to guarantee him the starting No. 1 shirt.

Skipper Locatelli adds to Juventus’ injury woes

Juventus captain Manuel Locatelli has been ruled out for reportedly up to six months after undergoing knee surgery, the record 36 times Serie A winner announced on Tuesday. The 28-year-old midfielder suffered the injury in Sunday’s 1-1 draw with AC Milan and joins winger Kenan Yildiz and playmaker Khephren Thuram in being sidelined for a long spell. Locatelli is expected to be out for between four and six months, according to local media.



Rune announces return after 11-month hiatus

Denmark’s Holger Rune announced he will return to competition next month having been sidelined for nearly a year due to injury. The 23-year-old will make his comeback in Denmark’s Davis Cup tie against Bulgaria on September 18.

Dembele, Kane and Mbappe headline *Ballon d’Or* shortlist

Last year’s winner Ousmane Dembele, Harry Kane and Kylian Mbappe are among the top contenders for the men’s *Ballon d’Or*. The 30 men’s and 30 women’s nominees were revealed by *France Football* magazine on Tuesday, with the winners to be announced in London on October 26. In the women’s field, two-time winner Alexia Putellas, Ewa Pajor and Melchie Dumornay are among the favourites.

Hardik named in India-A squad

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Hardik Pandya has been picked for the three-match one-day series against Australia-A in October subject to full fitness, the BCCI announced on Wednesday. The 32-year-old Pandya last played a competitive match during last edition’s disastrous IPL campaign for Mumbai Indians.

The tour will start with the first multi-day match in Puducherry from Sept. 22, followed by the second game from Sept. 29 at the same venue.

The multi-day matches will be followed by three one-dayers on October 6, 9 and 11 in Puducherry.

Devdutt Padikkal will lead the India A multi-day squad while Ruturaj Gaikwad will captain the one-day side in the upcoming home series in which they will play two multi-day red ball games and three 50-over matches.



Hardik. FILE PHOTO: EMMANUEL YOGINI

The squads: Multi-Day: Devdutt Padikkal (Capt.), Sai Sudharsan (Vice-capt.), Aman Mokhad, Ayush Pandey, Yash Rathod, Shaik Rasheed, Kumar Kushagra (wk), Shams Mulani, Tanush Kotian, Tushar Deshpande, Anshul Kamboj, Praful Hinge, N. Jagadeesan (wk), Nachiket Bhute and V. Vyshak.

One-Dayers: Ruturaj Gaikwad (Capt.), Devdutt Padikkal (Vice-capt.), Priyansh Arya, Sai Sudharsan, Rajat Patidar, Kumar Kushagra (wk), Nishant Sindhu, Vipraj Nigam, Arshin Kulkarni, Arshad Khan, Naman Dhir, Hardik Pandya, Prabhsimran Singh (wk), Gurjapneet Singh and Yash Thakur.

Ruthless Real makes Inter pay for its mistakes

Haaland brace fires Man City past Porto; Villa beats Belgian champion Club Brugge; Dortmund, runner-up in 2024, starts its campaign with a victory over Villarreal at home

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Jose Mourinho got off to a winning start on his return to the Champions League with Real Madrid on Tuesday as the Spanish giant beat Inter Milan 2-1, while Erling Haaland scored twice in Manchester City’s victory at Porto.

There were also wins for Aston Villa and Borussia Dortmund on the first night of action in this season’s league phase, as the opening matchday spreads across three nights.

Real was two goals ahead midway through the first half at the Bernabeu thanks to two gifts from the Inter defence, with Yann Bissecck at fault as Kylian Mbappe opened the scoring on his 99th appearance in the competition.

Mbappe has now scored 71 Champions League goals, equalling the tally of Real legend Raul.

The home side doubled its lead when Inter goalkeeper Josep Martinez tried to turn away from Fede Valverde inside his



Opportunistic: Valverde picks Inter ‘keeper Martinez’s pockets to score Real’s second. AP

own six-yard box only for the Uruguayan to tackle him and score.

Carlos Augusto pulled one back for Inter, but Real held on for the victory.

Enzo Maresca’s City won 2-0 away to Portuguese champion Porto thanks to a second-half brace by Haaland, the first coming two minutes after the restart when he headed in Enzo Fernandez’s cross.

Haaland sealed the points in stoppage time

and has now scored an astonishing 59 goals in 59 appearances in the competition.

Villa, last season’s Europa League winner, put its poor start to its domestic campaign behind as it beat Belgian champion Club Brugge 3-2 away.

Serhou Guirassy was the chief protagonist as Dortmund, runner-up in 2024, started its campaign with a 3-2 home win against Villarreal.

The results: Club Brugge 2 (Vetlesen 19, Tresoldi 61-pen) lost to Aston Villa 3 (McGinn 11, Buendia 22, Jackson 43). AEK Athens 1 (Marin 21) bt LASK 0.

Real Madrid 2 (Mbappe 14, Valverde 23) bt Inter Milan 1 (Carlos Augusto 77). Borussia Dortmund 3 (Veiga 53-og, Guirassy 80, 85-pen) bt Villarreal 2 (Mourino 66, Guirassy 90+3-og).

Porto 0 lost to Manchester City 2 (Haaland 47, 90+1).

Lille 2 (Ueda 12, Alessandro 36) lost to Real Betis 3 (Bartra 33, 49, Parrott 53).

Asiad-bound athletes set for one final test

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

The focus will squarely be on the big names travelling for the Asian Games as the invitation-only, season-ending Indian Athletics Final Series at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium here on Thursday is set to be the most decorated domestic event of the calendar year.

The Athletics Federation of India has opted for 30 disciplines – 15 each in men and women – in the one-day, single-session event. The cream of Indian track and field, including almost all the Asiad-bound names, will be looking to assess their competition worthiness one last time ahead of the continental extravaganza.

The athletes were invited as per their ranking across the Athletics Series through the year, with the quartermilers expected to be in the spotlight. In men’s 400m, National record holder Vishal T.K., Rajesh Ramesh, Manu T.S., Dharamveer Chaudhary, Mohammed Ashfaq and Jay Kumar have all been called up to compete.

Vishal has also been named in the 200m start list along with Animesh Kujur, who will also be gunning to regain his title of the fastest Indian man in 100m.

NR holder Gurindervir Singh and Harjit Singh are in the shortest sprint, the former hoping to allay fitness concerns. Also return-

Some of the athletes have been given exemption, including Sreeshankar (long jump), Praveen (triple jump) and Kushare (high jump)

ing to action after almost a year and half out with injury and rehab is Avinash Sable in 3000m steeplechase. Ten of the 15 Asian Games medallists from Hangzhou who are bound for Aichi-Nagoya have been named in the start list.

Missing out

There is no 200m for women while men’s discus throw hasn’t been included either. Harita Bhadra, a late addition to the Asiad squad after winning the 200m National Inter-State championships title in June with a season’s best effort, will be running in 100m along with Unnathi Bollanda Aiyappa.

Yashvir Singh, having made the cut after Neeraj Chopra was ruled out with injury, and Rohit Yadav, will both start in men’s javelin throw while Annu Rani will do so in the women’s section. Shot putter Tajinderpal Singh Toor will also compete for honours.

Some of the athletes have been given exemption, including Murali Sreeshankar (long jump), Praveen Chithravel (triple jump) and Sarvesh Kushare (high jump). The more gruelling events like middle and long-distance runs and decathlon have not been included.



Evaluation time: Vishal, centre, will compete in both 400m and 200m. FILE PHOTO: RITU RAJ KONWAR

Sheetal wins two medals, India finishes second in the table



Memorable: Sheetal pipped Kazakhstan’s Aizada to bag the individual gold after combining with Toman for the compound mixed team bronze. VIJAY SONEJI

PARA ARCHERY

Sports Bureau

Armless para-archer Sheetal Devi won two medals, including a gold, as India secured six medals on the concluding day of the World Archery Para Series

in Ahmedabad on Wednesday. The host finished second with its tally of four gold, three silver and eight bronze, behind Czechia, which topped the table with five gold.

Sheetal combined with Toman Kumar to get past Iraq’s Hameed Sarah and Kadhim Abbas 157-145 for

the compound mixed team bronze. Then, she pipped Kazakhstan’s Seidan Aizada 144-144 (shoot-off 10-9) in the final to bag the women’s individual gold.

In the recurve mixed team final, Bhawna and Harvinder Singh defeated China’s Lang Quirong and Xia Lei 6-0 to claim the

day’s second gold. Later, Bhawna outsmarted compatriot Rajshri Rathod 6-0 for the women’s individual bronze.

Toman went past Abbas 143-138, while Sarita beat China’s Wang Huiting 141-140 for compound men’s and women’s bronze medals respectively.

Wrestler picked for Asiad tests positive

Sports Bureau
KOLKATA

India received another setback in the run-up to the Asian Games with a third wrestler, Deepak (Greco-Roman 67kg), testing positive for a banned substance.

As a result, India will lose the spot in the mega event.

According to sources, Deepak was tested during the Asian Games trials in Lucknow on May 31 and returned a positive result for Clomifene.

Earlier, Mukul Dahiya (freestyle 86kg) and Deepanshu (Greco-Roman 130kg) had tested positive for banned substances.

Consequently, India has lost three wrestling berths out of a total of 18. Recently, the Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) had urged wrestlers to act responsibly on anti-doping matters.

Indian men in junior Asia Cup semifinals



Goal fest: India crushed Taiwan 15-0. HOCKEY INDIA

HOCKEY

Press Trust of India
MOQI (CHINA)

Skipper Anmol Ekka smashed six goals as defending champion India ended its pool engagements with a 15-0 rout of Taiwan to enter the men’s semifinals of junior Asia Cup hockey on Wednesday.

India topped Pool A with 10 points with three wins and a draw, while South

Mirabai will hope to break jinx and land an elusive medal

ASIAN GAMES

Y.B. Sarangi
KOLKATA



Mirabai. FILE PHOTO

While World and Olympic medallist weightlifter Mirabai Chanu is treading cautiously in search of an elusive Asian Games medal, Commonwealth Games silver medallist Chanambam Rishikanta Singh has been ruled out due to a recurring knee injury.

With no Chinese lifter in the fray in the women’s 49kg category, Mirabai – who won her third consecutive Commonwealth Games gold in Glasgow with an aggregate of 190kg – has her best chance to open her account in the continental extravaganza.

Mirabai missed the 2018 Asian Games due to a back issue and was injured on the competition platform during the next edition in 2023.

According to chief coach Vijay Sharma, seasoned North Korean Ri Song Gum, Thailand’s Kaesingkhon Suthasini and Taiwan’s Fang Wan-ling will be Mirabai’s main competitors. Since Ri is a notch above the rest, the 32-year-old Mirabai needs to beat the other two in a field of eight to break the jinx.

“Anything around a 200kg total would get us a

medal. A medal is our target, not the total,” Sharma told *The Hindu*.

Mirabai promptly resumed training after winning gold in Glasgow in July. “She needed to train as she was troubled by shoulder and wrist injuries after the National championships in February. Now, we are not overloading her and playing it safe. The focus is on her fitness,” said Sharma.

The coach added that the three other women lifters in the Indian squad – Gyaneshwari Yadav (53kg), Nirupama Devi (61kg) and Harjinder Kaur (69kg) – would try to achieve their personal bests.

Rishikanta (60kg), the lone male weightlifter in the Indian squad, will not compete in Japan. “He has been carrying the injury for some time. He managed to claim the Commonwealth Games silver despite the injury. But he will not be able to take part in the Asian Games.”

Indian women’s rugby sevens begin Asiad preparations

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

The Indian senior women’s rugby sevens team has begun its preparation for the upcoming Asian Games here with coach Terence Joseph saying the focus of the National camp will be on execution and consistency.

The Indian women will compete in the rugby sevens tournament in Nagoya from October 1 to 3. The country has been drawn in Pool B alongside defending champion China, Hong Kong China and Malaysia.

“We are looking at details and consistency. A lot depends on how we execute our plans,” Joseph said.

A total of 20 players are attending the National camp, sanctioned by SAI, at ₹19.8 lakh.

Indian women finished seventh at the Hangzhou Asian Games in 2022.

